

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Modern History 04 - The British Conquest of Bengal (Plassey 1757, Buxar 1764, Dual Government) - Complete Learning Session

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

MODERN HISTORY - TOPIC 04

The British Conquest of Bengal

Plassey 1757 * Buxar 1764 * Dual Government 1765-72 | GS-I Modern Indian History | Date: 2026-08-19 | Full learning-session export.

FOCUS

1756-1772: the Calcutta crisis, Plassey, Mir Jafar and Mir Qasim, Buxar, the Treaty of Allahabad, the Diwani/Nizamat split, and the Dual Government.

EXAM MOVE

Prelims: hold farman/dastak, Diwani/Nizamat and date precision. Mains: frame the conquest as a political-commercial process, not one battle.

EVIDENCE

Bipin Chandra's Modern India and Sekhar Bandyopadhyay's From Plassey to Partition, cross-checked against the repository's basic/advanced files and PYQ ledgers.

CAUTION

No invented Black Hole casualty figure, no monocausal famine claim, no drain-theory depth owned by Topic 07 -- boundaries are held throughout.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Modern History 04 - The British Conquest of Bengal (Plassey 1757, Buxar 1764, Dual Government) - Complete Learning Session

Subject: Modern Indian History | GS-I | Prelims and Mains | Date: 2026-08-19.

Source order followed: Topic 04 basic/advanced Markdown; the Master Chronology and the repository's PYQ routing ledgers and PYQ-integration audits (2018-2023, 2024-2025, 2026); OCR-searchable local editions of Bipin Chandra's *India's Struggle for Independence / History of Modern India* and Sekhar Bandyopadhyay's *From Plassey to Partition*; a live official heritage check for a defensible current anchor; bounded links to Modern History Topics 03, 05, 06 and 07. FACT statements are source-grounded; ANALYSIS statements are qualified; no single-cause explanation and no invented number is offered anywhere in this package.

MODERN HISTORY - TOPIC 04

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Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04

Visual 0: the British conquest of Bengal -- frame, evidence and exam moves

Visual 0: the British conquest of Bengal -- frame, evidence and exam moves. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Learning roadmap

1. Bengal's political economy before 1756
2. Siraj-ud-Daulah and the Calcutta crisis
3. The Black Hole of Calcutta: evidence and its limits
4. Plassey's hidden battle: the conspiracy network
5. Plassey, 23 June 1757: coup, not conventional triumph
6. Mir Jafar's Bengal and Company extraction, 1757-60
7. Mir Qasim, Munger and the equality crisis, 1760-63
8. The road to Buxar: a three-power coalition forms
9. Buxar, 22 October 1764: the more decisive battle
10. The Treaty of Allahabad, 1765: Diwani, Nizamat, two settlements
11. The Dual Government, 1765-72: an accountability paradox
12. The Bengal famine of 1770: a bounded causal reading
13. From trader to revenue sovereign: Company transformation and Indian agency
14. Reading the conquest: four historiographical lenses
15. Comparative synthesis and the bridge to Topics 06-07
16. Sources, PYQ audit and practice.

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST

Book context: queried - Topic 04 basic/advanced notes, the Master Chronology, the repository's PYQ-integration audits for 2018-2023, 2024-2025 and 2026, and the Prelims/Mains routing ledgers were checked, alongside OCR-searchable local chapters of Bipan Chandra and Sekhar Bandyopadhyay covering the Bengal conquest and the Dual Government. Modern History Topic 03 (European Company beginnings) is assumed as background, not repeated; Topics 05, 06 and 07 are named only as the bounded forward hand-off.

CA Search: "Hazarduari Palace Murshidabad ASI Archaeological Survey of India conservation restoration news 2025 2026"

CA Found: Hazarduari Palace at Murshidabad (a Monument of National Importance under ASI care since 1985, standing on the historic Nizamat Fort campus) had its long-silent tower clock ("Ghari Ghar") restored by specialist artisans in March 2025; the Ministry of Culture separately allocated Rs 376.88 crore nationally for 2025-26 conservation, preservation and environmental development of all centrally protected ASI monuments, of which Hazarduari is one beneficiary among many. Verify any further 2026 site-specific allocation or event officially before citing new specifics. STATIC LINK retained for exam use: Murshidabad's Nizamat Fort campus is the standing heritage anchor for Bengal's Nawabi seat and the Nawab-Company relationship this topic teaches (Hazarduari Palace itself was built in the 1830s, after this topic's own 1757-72 window, on the same historic campus); the conservation detail is a heritage-linkage note, not an examinable historical fact about 1757-72.

PART I - BENGAL BEFORE THE STORM

1. Bengal's political economy before 1756: Murshid Quli Khan, Alivardi Khan and the limits of Company privilege

By the middle of the eighteenth century Bengal was Mughal India's richest subah -- a dense, overlapping web of political authority and commercial opportunity, not a power vacuum waiting to be filled. Murshid Quli Khan, appointed Diwan of Bengal under Aurangzeb and later its de facto Nawab, had shifted the provincial capital from Dhaka to Murshidabad (named for himself) and built a stable ijaradari (revenue-farming) settlement that reduced jagir turnover and tied Bengal's finances closely to the Jagat Seth banking house, which financed the Nawab's treasury and, in time, much of Bengal's internal and external trade. His successors held this settlement together through the 1720s and 1730s; Alivardi Khan then took the throne after defeating and killing Sarfaraz Khan in 1740, and spent much of his reign containing repeated Maratha Bargi raids into western Bengal before agreeing, in 1751, to cede Orissa and pay an annual chauth to keep the Marathas out altogether. Alivardi died in April 1756 and was succeeded by his grandson, Siraj-ud-Daulah.

FACT: the English East India Company's core commercial privilege in Bengal rested on the 1717 farman of the Mughal emperor Farrukhsiyar, which confirmed duty-free import and export of the Company's own registered goods and the Company's right to issue dastak passes certifying such cargo as duty-exempt -- an extension of an earlier 1690s Aurangzeb-era concession, layered on Calcutta's existing zamindari and fortification rights. **ANALYSIS:** this was a real, treaty-based commercial privilege, not an unlimited licence, and every Bengal Nawab from Murshid Quli Khan onward treated it as exactly that -- a bounded exemption for the Company's own trade, not a cover for private profiteering by its servants or their Indian agents, which is precisely the distinction the next subtopic examines in detail.

Company privilege and Nawabi political authority overlapped at every major node of Bengal's political economy: Murshidabad (the Nawab's capital, mint and the Jagat Seths' headquarters), Kasimbazar (English, Dutch and French silk factories), Calcutta and Fort William (Company headquarters, fortified from 1755 without the Nawab's permission), Chandernagore (the rival French factory) and Hughli and Dhaka (older Mughal-era ports and administrative seats). This structural overlap -- not any single flashpoint -- produced the recurring friction that Siraj-ud-Daulah inherited in 1756, and it is why Part II treats the Calcutta crisis as an escalation ladder rather than a single act of provocation.

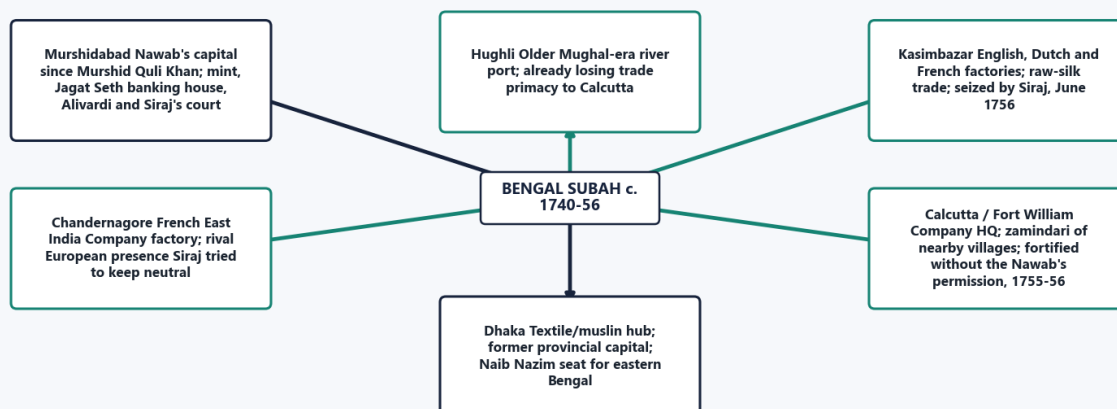
Bengal's political economy before 1756: power and commerce nodes

PRE-CONQUEST MAP

SCHEMATIC RELATIVE-POSITION SKETCH -- NOT A SURVEYED MAP, NOT TO SCALE

● Political/administrative node

● Commercial/company node



Company privilege (the 1717 farman) and Nawabi political authority overlapped at every one of these nodes -- that structural overlap, not any single flashpoint, produced recurring conflict.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Bengal's political economy before 1756

Visual 1: Bengal's political economy before 1756: power and commerce nodes

Visual 1: Bengal's political economy before 1756: power and commerce nodes. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

FACT: Company servants and their Indian trading partners routinely sold or misused dastak passes to cover private trade that had nothing to do with the Company's own registered goods, evading internal transit duties that Indian merchants continued to pay in full. ANALYSIS: Murshid Quli Khan, Alivardi Khan and Siraj-ud-Daulah in turn all resisted this extension of the 1717 privilege, because it was never authorised by any farman -- a careful Prelims-facing answer must hold this exact line: the 1717 farman was a real, Company-only, treaty-based exemption, while dastak abuse by servants and their agents was an unauthorised extension that no Nawab ever accepted, and confusing the two is the single most common error in Prelims-style option-writing on this period.

The 1717 farman and the dastak: privilege vs abuse

PRELIMS-CRITICAL

The Company's privilege (1717 Farrukhsiyar farman)

Duty-free import/export of the COMPANY's own registered goods in Bengal; the right to issue dastak passes certifying such cargo; built on the 1690s Aurangzeb-era concession and Calcutta's earlier zamindari and fortification rights.

Servants' private-trade abuse (what Nawabs actually contested)

Company servants privately sold or misused dastaks to cover their own and Indian agents' private trade, evading duties that Indian merchants still had to pay in full. Murshid Quli Khan, Alivardi Khan and Siraj-ud-Daulah all resisted this extension.

Same instrument, two rival claims: this exact separation is what Prelims tests.

Do not conflate the 1717 privilege (real, treaty-based, Company-only) with servants' dastak abuse (an unauthorised extension no Nawab accepted) -- examiners reward exactly this split.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Farman and dastak: privilege vs abuse

Visual 2: The 1717 farman and the dastak: privilege vs abuse

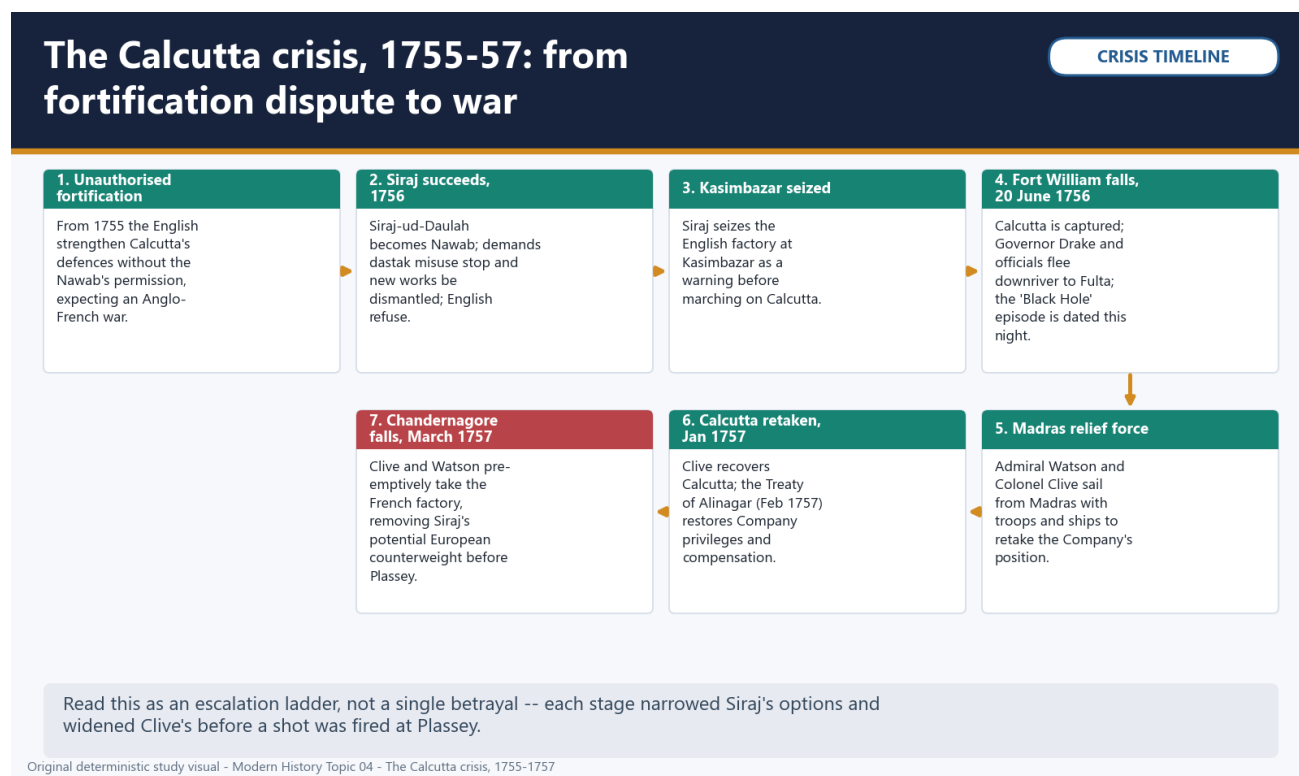
PART II - THE CALCUTTA CRISIS AND ITS MEMORY

2. Siraj-ud-Daulah, the Calcutta crisis and the fall of Fort William, 1756

Siraj-ud-Daulah succeeded his grandfather Alivardi Khan in April 1756 as a young, insecure ruler facing rival claimants within his own court and a Company that had, since 1755, been strengthening Fort William's defences without seeking his permission -- ostensibly in anticipation of the wider Anglo-French war then breaking out in Europe (the Seven Years' War, 1756-63), which threatened to spill into Bengal through the rival English and French factories at Calcutta and Chandernagore. Siraj demanded that the English stop this unauthorised fortification and dismantle what had already been built; when the Calcutta Council under Governor Roger Drake refused or prevaricated, Siraj moved from warning to action.

FACT: Siraj first seized the English factory at Kasimbazar in early June 1756 as a demonstrative warning, then marched on Calcutta itself and captured Fort William on 20 June 1756; Drake and most senior officials fled downriver to Fulta, leaving the fort's remaining defenders to surrender. ANALYSIS: read as a single ladder rather than one betrayal, each stage of this escalation narrowed Siraj's options and widened the Company's -- the unauthorised fortification created the original grievance, the Company's refusal to climb down converted a demand into a demonstration of resolve, and the fall of Calcutta itself then created the very opening (a humiliated Company needing to recover its position by force) that Robert Clive and Admiral Charles Watson exploited from Madras.

The Company's response came in two stages. Clive and Watson sailed from Madras with troops and warships, recovered Calcutta on 2 January 1757, and secured the Treaty of Alinagar in February 1757, which restored the Company's trading privileges and compensation for its losses. They then moved pre-emptively against Chandernagore in March 1757, seizing the French factory and removing Siraj's potential European counterweight before any confrontation with the Nawab himself -- a calculated step that left Siraj diplomatically isolated just as the Plassey conspiracy, examined in Part III, was reaching maturity.



Visual 3: The Calcutta crisis, 1755-1757: from fortification dispute to war

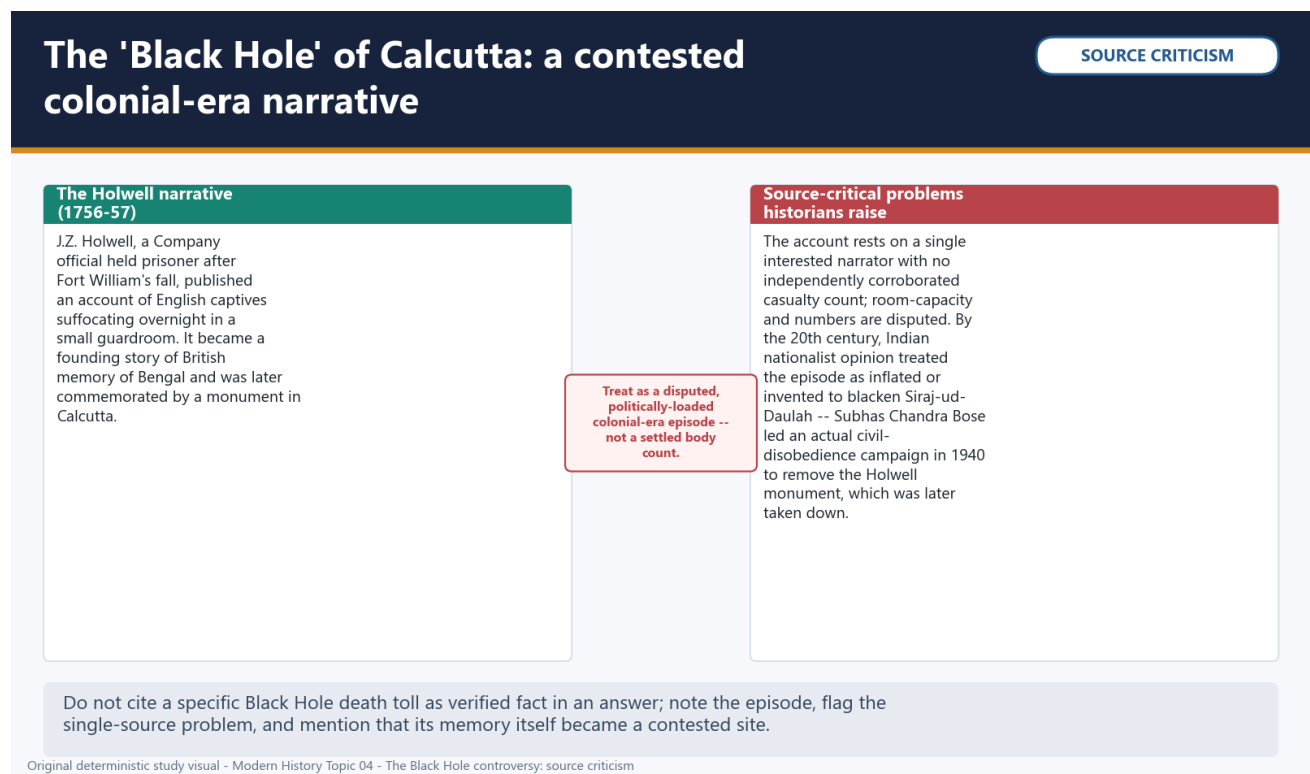
Visual 3: The Calcutta crisis, 1755-1757: from fortification dispute to war. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

3. The 'Black Hole' of Calcutta: what the evidence supports, and what it does not

The best-known episode of the Calcutta crisis is also its most historiographically contested. J.Z. Holwell, a Company official captured when Fort William fell, later published an account describing English prisoners suffocating overnight, on 20-21 June 1756, in a small guardroom at the fort -- an episode that became known as the 'Black Hole of Calcutta' and, for generations of British readers, a founding atrocity story about Bengal.

FACT: Holwell's account rests on a single interested narrator -- a survivor with every institutional and personal incentive to dramatise his own ordeal -- and no independently corroborated casualty count exists; the room's capacity and the number of prisoners involved are both disputed in the historical record. **ANALYSIS:** source-critical practice requires treating a single-witness, self-interested account as exactly that, not as a settled body count, and a careful answer should note the evidentiary weakness explicitly rather than either repeating a specific death toll as fact or (equally unjustifiably) declaring the whole episode invented; the defensible position is agnosticism about the exact numbers, combined with clarity that the episode was real in some form but became inflated and politically instrumentalised in British colonial memory.

This is not merely an antiquarian dispute: the episode's memory became a live political site in the twentieth century. By that period, Indian nationalist opinion increasingly treated the Holwell narrative as exaggerated or invented specifically to blacken Siraj-ud-Daulah's reputation and retrospectively justify Company conquest; Subhas Chandra Bose led an actual civil-disobedience campaign in 1940 demanding the removal of the Holwell memorial in Calcutta, and the monument was subsequently taken down. A defensible Mains-facing treatment of the Black Hole therefore does two things at once: it declines to cite a precise casualty figure as verified fact, and it notes that the episode's contested memory -- not just the event itself -- is part of what a complete historical account must explain.



Visual 4: The 'Black Hole' of Calcutta: a contested colonial-era narrative

Visual 4: The 'Black Hole' of Calcutta: a contested colonial-era narrative. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

PART III - PLASSEY, 1757

4. Plassey's hidden battle: the conspiracy network of 1757

While the Chandernagore operation was underway, Clive and the Calcutta Council were simultaneously negotiating, from Fulta and Calcutta, a parallel political plot to replace Siraj-ud-Daulah with a more compliant Nawab. This conspiracy drew together a disaffected court faction with genuinely independent grievances against Siraj, not a group Clive invented from nothing: Mir Jafar, Siraj's Mir Bakshi (army paymaster and senior commander), stood to gain the throne itself and kept his own large contingent out of the Plassey fighting; the Jagat Seth banking house (led by Mahtab Rai and Swarup Chand), Bengal's leading financiers, feared Siraj's hostility to their commercial and political position and both financed and lent legitimacy to the plot; Rai Durlabh, Bengal's Diwan, brought fiscal and administrative backing and likewise held his contingent back from battle; and Amichand (Omichand), a wealthy Armenian-Bengali merchant-financier, served as the crucial go-between with Clive.

FACT: because Amichand knew enough about the conspiracy to threaten exposure unless he received a five per cent commission from the Nawab's treasury, Clive had two versions of the treaty prepared -- a genuine one on white paper without any clause for Amichand, and a second, fraudulent one on red paper carrying the commission clause, which was shown to Amichand alone; Admiral Watson refused to sign the fraudulent copy, so Clive had Watson's signature forged onto it. ANALYSIS: this episode is frequently cited as the clearest single instance of Clive's personal conduct at Plassey, and it matters analytically because it shows that deception was not confined to the conspiracy's Indian participants alone -- the Company's own commander defrauded his co-conspirator exactly as he was defrauding the sitting Nawab, which complicates any account that reduces Plassey to Indian betrayal alone.

Historians continue to debate whether the conspiracy originated within Murshidabad's own disaffected court faction or was substantially assembled and driven from Calcutta by Clive; what is not seriously disputed is the underlying collusion itself, between a genuinely alienated faction at Siraj's court and a Company willing to use bribery, forged documents and secret letters to engineer regime change before a single major battle was fought.

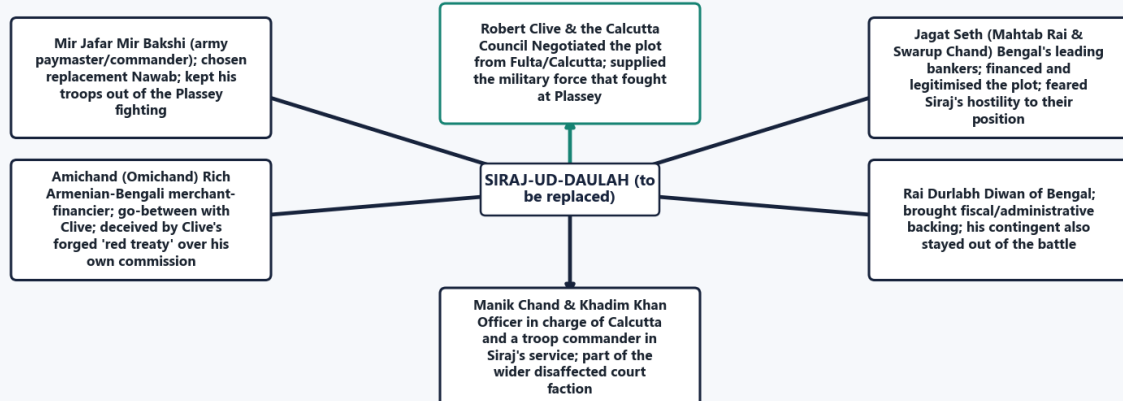
The Plassey conspiracy, 1757: who wanted Siraj replaced, and why

COUP NETWORK

SCHEMATIC INTEREST-NETWORK -- ARROWS SHOW POLITICAL ALIGNMENT, NOT MILITARY MOVEMENT

● Indian court/financial actor

● Company/European actor



Historians debate whether the conspiracy began at Murshidabad or was assembled by Clive -- what is settled is the collusion between a disaffected court faction and the Company.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - The Plassey conspiracy network

Visual 5: The Plassey conspiracy, 1757: who wanted Siraj replaced, and why

Visual 5: The Plassey conspiracy, 1757: who wanted Siraj replaced, and why. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

5. Plassey, 23 June 1757: why this was a political coup, not a conventional military triumph

The battle fought at Plassey on 23 June 1757 is the best-known date in this topic, and also the most commonly misdescribed. Siraj-ud-Daulah's nominal army heavily outnumbered Clive's Company force, yet numbers barely mattered once the conspiracy had already neutralised the largest wings of that army: Mir Jafar's and Rai Durlabh's contingents, together the bulk of Siraj's strength, had a prior understanding with Clive and gave no order to engage. Real combat that day was confined to the smaller, genuinely loyal wing commanded by Mir Madan and Mohan Lal, which fought hard in an artillery exchange until Mir Madan was mortally wounded; once he fell, Siraj's headquarters lost its nerve, and Siraj -- advised, ironically, by the same Mir Jafar who had already agreed to replace him -- ordered a general retreat. Siraj fled the field, was captured attempting to escape further, and was executed on the orders of Mir Jafar's son Miran on 2 July 1757.

FACT: the traditionally cited casualty figures for Plassey are markedly lopsided -- commonly given as around 29 dead on the Company's side against several hundred, often cited as close to 500, among Siraj's forces -- though these are the standard figures repeated in general secondary accounts rather than exact, independently audited modern counts, and should be treated with the same caution as any inherited eighteenth-century casualty estimate. ANALYSIS: precisely because the fighting itself was this lopsided and this brief, the decisive factor at Plassey was not superior Company generalship or firepower in an open contest but the pre-arranged political conspiracy examined in subtopic 4 -- a matrix comparison makes the point directly: where a conventional military triumph would show a full day's pitched battle deciding the outcome through force of arms, what Plassey actually shows is numbers rendered irrelevant by a bargain struck in advance, with the fighting itself serving mainly to validate a political transaction rather than decide it.

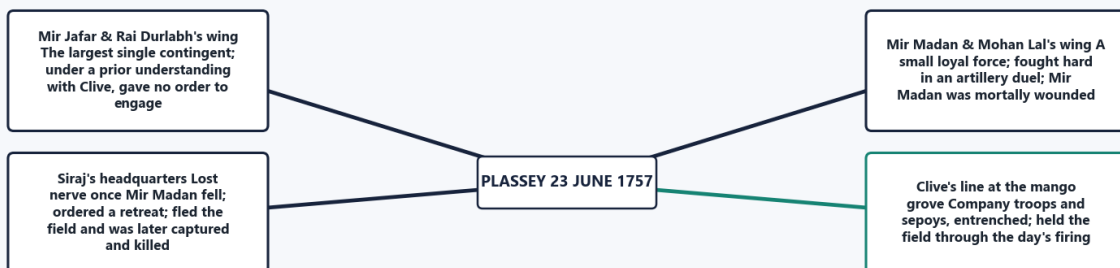
The Plassey battlefield, 23 June 1757: a schematic sketch

NOT TO SCALE

SCHEMATIC BATTLEFIELD SKETCH -- NOT TO SCALE, POSITIONS APPROXIMATE

● Nawab's court/military actor

● Company force



Weigh the map against the casualty count: the English lost 29 men; the Nawab's side lost close to 500. A battle this one-sided was already decided off the field.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - The Plassey battlefield, 23 June 1757 (schematic, not to scale)

Visual 6: The Plassey battlefield, 23 June 1757: a schematic sketch

Visual 6: The Plassey battlefield, 23 June 1757: a schematic sketch. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Describing Plassey correctly in an examination therefore means describing a negotiated transfer of power validated by a brief, one-sided skirmish -- not a hard-fought battlefield victory that happened to change the throne. The immediate settlement installed Mir Jafar as Nawab and made the Company Bengal's de facto political kingmaker, but -- and this limit matters for what follows -- it did not yet make the Company Bengal's ruler in any legal sense; that further, more consequential step required Buxar and the Treaty of Allahabad, examined in Parts IV and V.

Plassey: a political coup, not a conventional military triumph

COUP vs BATTLE

	What a conventional triumph would show	What actually happened at Plassey
Force ratio	Nawab's nominal army was several times the size of the Company's force	Numbers barely mattered once the largest wings had agreed not to fight
Actual fighting	A full day's pitched battle across both armies on an open field	Real combat was confined to Mir Madan and Mohan Lal's small loyal wing
Decisive factor	Superior generalship or firepower deciding an open contest	A pre-arranged conspiracy involving Mir Jafar, Jagat Seth, Rai Durlabh and Amichand
Casualties	Heavy losses on both sides matching the scale of the armies engaged	English losses were 29; the Nawab's side lost nearly 500 -- a lopsided, short affair
Outcome secured by	Battlefield victory alone deciding who would rule Bengal next	Prior letters, bribes, and the promise of the throne to Mir Jafar
What changed	A single day's military result and nothing more	A change of regime: Mir Jafar as Nawab, the Company as Bengal's political kingmaker

Exam framing: describe Plassey as a negotiated transfer of power validated by a brief skirmish -- not as a hard-fought battlefield victory that happened to change the throne.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Plassey as political coup vs conventional battle

Visual 7: Plassey: a political coup, not a conventional military triumph

Visual 7: Plassey: a political coup, not a conventional military triumph. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

PART IV - MIR JAFAR, MIR QASIM AND THE ROAD TO BUXAR

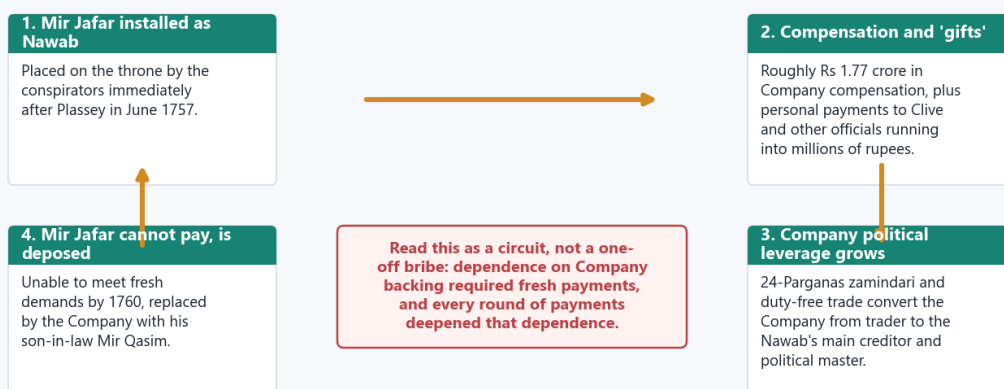
6. Mir Jafar's Bengal and Company extraction, 1757-60

Mir Jafar's installation as Nawab immediately after Plassey converted the conspiracy's political bargain into a running financial and political relationship, not a one-off reward. The Company and its individual officials received roughly Rs 1.77 crore in formal compensation from Mir Jafar's treasury, on top of separate personal payments to Clive and other officials that ran into millions of rupees -- Clive's own share, combined with a substantial jagir grant, made him one of the wealthiest Company servants ever to return from India, and his later parliamentary testimony ("at this moment I stand astonished at my own moderation") is often cited precisely because it was delivered in his own defence against corruption charges, not as a boast. Mir Jafar also ceded the zamindari of the 24 Parganas near Calcutta to the Company, converting it from a mere trading concern into a substantial territorial revenue-holder in its own right even before any Diwani grant existed.

FACT: this extraction operated as a repeating circuit rather than a single transaction -- Mir Jafar's dependence on Company military backing to hold his own throne required continual fresh payments, and each round of payment deepened his financial dependence on the Company, which in turn deepened the Company's political leverage over him. ANALYSIS: by 1760 Mir Jafar could no longer meet the Company's escalating fresh demands (driven partly by the Company's own regional military commitments, including operations against the Dutch at Chinsura in 1759), and the Company deposed him in favour of his son-in-law, Mir Qasim -- a sequence that shows extraction and political control as mutually reinforcing rather than as a single bribe followed by stable rule. It is worth being precise about scope here: this subtopic bounds itself to 1757-60 Company leverage and personal fortunes; the fuller structural drain-of-wealth analysis, spanning land revenue and the broader colonial economy, is Topic 07's material, not repeated here.

The post-Plassey extraction circuit, 1757-60

EXTRACTION LOOP



Bound this to 1757-60: post-1760 drain mechanics under the Diwani belong to Topic 07.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - The post-Plassey extraction circuit, 1757-60

Visual 8: The post-Plassey extraction circuit, 1757-60

Visual 8: The post-Plassey extraction circuit, 1757-60. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

7. Mir Qasim, Munger and the equality crisis, 1760-63

Mir Qasim, installed in 1760, was a considerably more capable and assertive ruler than his predecessor, and his reign is best read as a genuine reform effort colliding with the very Company leverage that had installed him. He shifted his capital from Murshidabad to Munger (Monghyr) in Bihar, deliberately putting distance between himself and Calcutta's overbearing influence while positioning himself closer to his own recruits and revenue base; he reorganised revenue collection to strengthen his own fiscal position, and rebuilt a retrained, partly European-drilled army and artillery corps commanded in part by European mercenaries in his service, seeking real military self-sufficiency rather than dependence on Company protection.

FACT: in 1763, in direct response to the continuing abuse of dastak privileges by Company servants and their Indian agents -- who used tax-free passes to undercut Indian merchants who still paid internal transit duties in full -- Mir Qasim abolished internal transit duties altogether, for Indian and English private traders alike. **ANALYSIS:** Mir Qasim's stated aim was equal, uniform taxation for all merchants regardless of nationality, not an anti-British nationalist gesture in the modern sense; the Company's Calcutta Council, however, read this fairness measure as an intolerable threat to its private-trade profits precisely because it erased the very tax advantage that dastak abuse had manufactured, and rejected equal treatment outright -- a useful corrective to any answer that flattens Mir Qasim's reform into simple anti-colonial resistance, when his own aim was administrative and commercial parity, with conflict with the Company as a consequence rather than his primary objective.

Confrontation escalated through 1763: an exchange of hostilities between Mir Qasim's forces and Company detachments culminated in the killing of a large number of European prisoners at Patna in October 1763 -- an episode remembered as the Patna Massacre and carried out under commanders in Mir Qasim's service after fighting had already broken out -- while Mir Qasim's own forces suffered a rapid series of defeats at Company hands at Katwa, Giria and Uddhanna later that year. Defeated and with his own territory lost, Mir Qasim fled to Awadh to seek the protection of its Nawab-Wazir, Shuja-ud-Daula, setting the stage for the coalition examined next.

Mir Qasim, 1760-63: reform, equal treatment, and conflict with the Company

REFORM CHAIN

1. Capital moved to Munger

Mir Qasim shifts his capital away from Murshidabad toward Bihar's frontier, closer to his own recruits and revenues.

2. Revenue and army reforms

Reorganises revenue collection and raises a retrained, partly European-drilled army and artillery corps.

3. Abolishes internal transit duties, 1763

Removes all internal duties on Indian merchants, ending Company servants' unfair tax-free private-trade edge.

6. Defeat and flight to Awadh

Mir Qasim is defeated in a series of 1763 engagements and flees to seek Shuja-ud-Daula's protection in Awadh.

5. Patna clashes escalate

Confrontations between Mir Qasim's forces and Company detachments escalate through 1763.

4. Company servants' backlash

English private traders protest the loss of their advantage; the Calcutta Council rejects equal treatment.

Mir Qasim's aim was equal, uniform taxation for all merchants, Indian and European alike -- the Company read that fairness as an intolerable threat to its private-trade profits.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Mir Qasim's reforms and conflict with the Company, 1760-63

Visual 9: Mir Qasim, 1760-63: reform, equal treatment, and conflict with the Company

Visual 9: Mir Qasim, 1760-63: reform, equal treatment, and conflict with the Company. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

8. The road to Buxar: Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II form a coalition

Mir Qasim's flight to Awadh in 1763 produced an alliance of genuine but distinct interests rather than a single unified anti-Company front. Mir Qasim, the deposed Nawab, had the deepest personal stake of the three and brought his own treasury and his drilled army to the alliance. Shuja-ud-Daula, Awadh's Nawab-Wazir, joined chiefly for the prospect of gaining Bihar and a promised indemnity from Mir Qasim, calculating that a weakened Company presence on his eastern frontier served Awadh's own interests. Shah Alam II, the fugitive Mughal emperor who had proclaimed himself emperor in Bihar in 1759 after his father Alamgir II's murder in Delhi, sought the coalition's military help to secure his own restoration and had every reason to see a reversal of Company power in Bengal and Bihar as a step toward that goal.

FACT: each of the three coalition partners retained control of their own treasury and their own military contingent, with no single supreme commander and no shared war-chest; coordination depended on shifting personal trust between three rulers who did not, in fact, fully trust one another. ANALYSIS: this segmented command structure is the analytical key to why the coalition ultimately lost to a numerically smaller but unified Company force under Hector Munro at Buxar -- three motives and three separate commanders produced one alliance in name but not one army in practice, a structural weakness examined directly in the next subtopic's comparison with the Company's command.

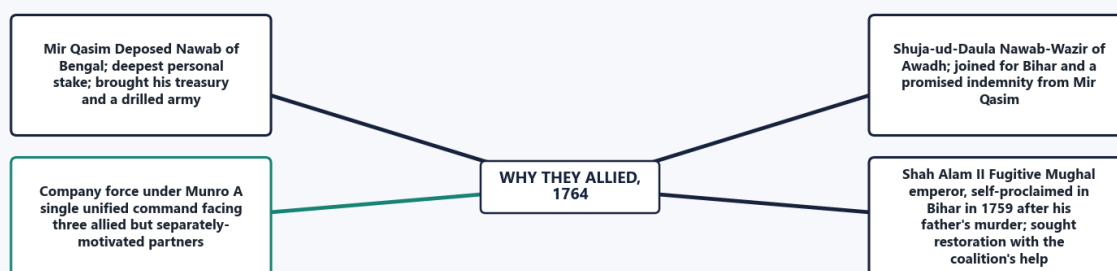
The Buxar coalition, 1764: three partners, three motives

COALITION MAP

SCHEMATIC INTEREST-NETWORK -- ARROWS SHOW POLITICAL ALIGNMENT, NOT TROOP MOVEMENT

● Coalition partner

● Company force



Three motives, three commanders, one alliance -- that plural command, not a lack of courage, is the analytical key to why Buxar went the Company's way.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - The Buxar coalition, 1764

Visual 10: The Buxar coalition, 1764: three partners, three motives

Visual 10: The Buxar coalition, 1764: three partners, three motives. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

PART V - BUXAR AND ALLAHABAD

9. Buxar, 22 October 1764: why this battle mattered more than Plassey

The coalition's combined forces met a unified Company army under Hector Munro at Buxar on 22 October 1764. Where Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II each retained separate treasuries and contingents with no shared command, Munro commanded one integrated force with a single chain of command, one supply and pay system, and one battle plan -- a structural advantage that outweighed the coalition's larger combined numbers and produced a comparatively decisive Company victory.

FACT: unlike Plassey, which was settled chiefly through a pre-arranged political conspiracy with minimal real fighting, Buxar was a harder-fought, more conventional pitched battle against a genuine coalition army, decided principally by the coalition's segmented command structure rather than by any comparable political arrangement beforehand.

ANALYSIS: this is precisely why Buxar, not Plassey, is the strategically more decisive of the two engagements for a Mains-facing answer -- Plassey changed who occupied Bengal's throne, but it was Buxar that broke the coalition capable of contesting Company power across Bengal, Bihar and Awadh, clearing the path to the legal settlement examined next; an answer that treats Plassey alone as "the conquest of Bengal" misses the further, arguably more consequential step that Buxar and Allahabad supplied.

Buxar, 22 October 1764: why segmented command lost to unified command

COMMAND STRUCTURE

The coalition's segmented command

Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II each retained control of their own treasury and contingent. There was no single supreme commander and no shared war-chest; coordination relied on shifting personal trust between three rulers who did not fully trust one another.

The Company's unified command

Hector Munro commanded one integrated force with a single chain of command, one supply and pay system, and one battle plan at Buxar on 22 October 1764 -- a structural advantage that outweighed the coalition's larger combined numbers.

Segmented command lost to unified command

Exam framing: read Buxar as a test of command structure and logistics, not firepower alone -- bounded reference; full territorial-expansion detail belongs to Topic 05.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Why Buxar was strategically more decisive than Plassey

Visual 11: Buxar, 22 October 1764: why segmented command lost to unified command

Visual 11: Buxar, 22 October 1764: why segmented command lost to unified command. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Exam framing should read Buxar as a test of command structure and logistics rather than of firepower alone; the fuller territorial-expansion narrative that follows from this military outcome -- the Company's subsequent campaigns and relationships with other regional powers -- is bounded here and belongs in full to Modern History Topic 05.

Plassey vs Buxar: comparing the two turning points

COMPARISON

	Plassey, 1757	Buxar, 1764
Nature of the fight	A brief, one-sided skirmish decided mainly by a pre-arranged conspiracy	A harder-fought, more conventional pitched battle against a real coalition army
Who was defeated	A single Nawab (Siraj-ud-Daulah) with divided, half-loyal generals	A three-part coalition: a deposed Nawab, the Wazir of Awadh, and the Mughal emperor
Company command	Clive led a relatively small Company force reinforced from Madras	Munro commanded a unified force built on Bengal's post-Plassey resources
Key mechanism	Personal conspiracy and payments substituted for a real military contest	Superior unified command defeated a larger but segmented coalition army
Immediate outcome	Mir Jafar installed as a Company-dependent Nawab	Treaty of Allahabad, 1765: Diwani of Bengal-Bihar-Orissa granted to the Company
Strategic significance	Made the Company Bengal's political kingmaker in practice	Made the Company a recognised revenue-sovereign in law -- the more decisive turn

Exam trap: Plassey is the famous name, but Buxar and Allahabad did the legal and strategic work -- date-precision on which event caused which change is repeatedly tested.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Plassey vs Buxar: comparative significance

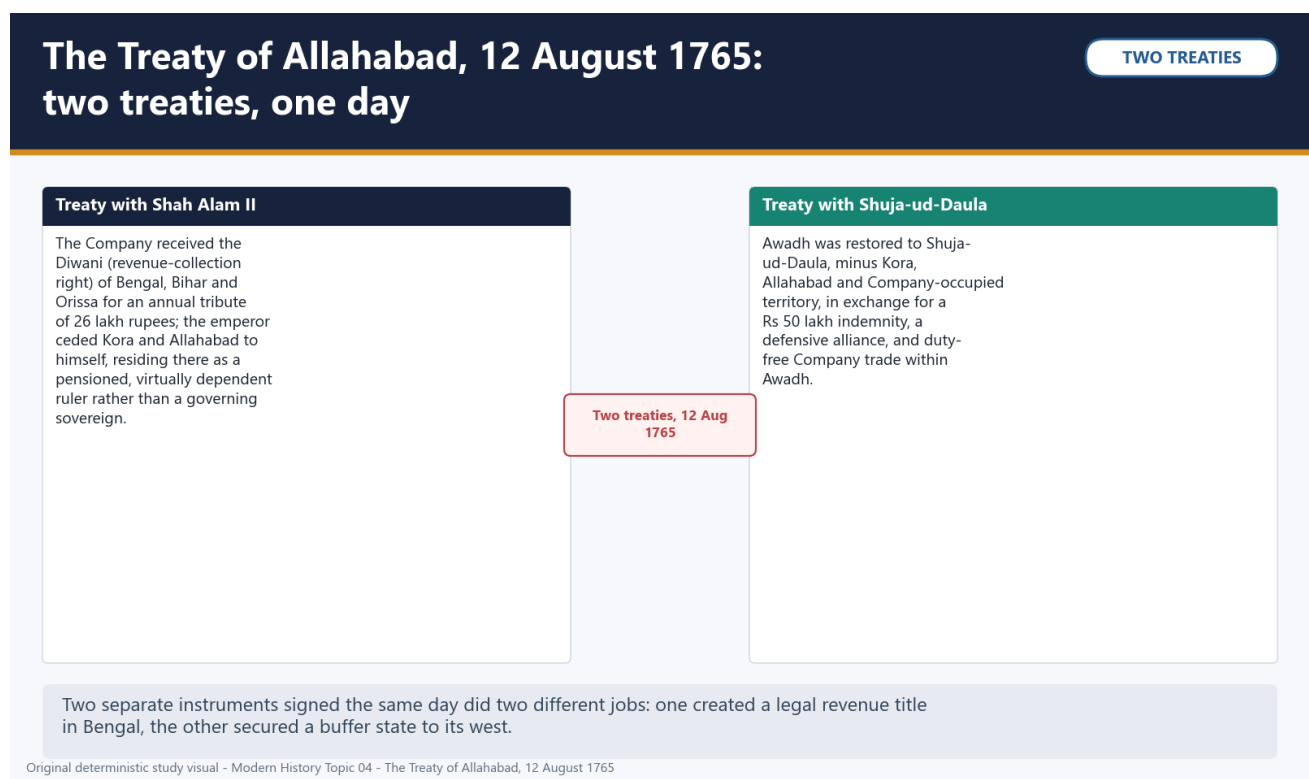
Visual 12: Plassey vs Buxar: comparing the two turning points

Visual 12: Plassey vs Buxar: comparing the two turning points. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

10. The Treaty of Allahabad, 1765: two treaties, one day

Buxar's aftermath was settled diplomatically, not simply by continued conquest. On 12 August 1765, two separate treaties were signed at Allahabad, each doing a different job. Under the treaty with Shah Alam II, the Company received the Diwani -- the right to collect and administer land revenue -- of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa, in exchange for an annual tribute of 26 lakh rupees to the emperor; in the same instrument, the emperor ceded the districts of Kora and Allahabad to himself, where he took up residence as a pensioned ruler substantially dependent on Company protection rather than as a governing sovereign in any effective sense. Under the separate treaty with Shuja-ud-Daula, Awadh was restored to him -- minus Kora, Allahabad and territory already occupied by the Company -- in exchange for a 50 lakh rupee war indemnity, a defensive alliance, and duty-free Company trade within Awadh.

FACT: these were two distinct legal instruments signed on the same day, not one combined settlement -- the Shah Alam II treaty created a legal revenue title for the Company in Bengal, Bihar and Orissa, while the Shuja-ud-Daula treaty separately secured Awadh as a buffer state to the Company's west. ANALYSIS: a Prelims-facing answer must be able to state which treaty did which job; a Mains-facing answer should further note that receiving the Diwani through an emperor still formally recognised as the ultimate source of legal authority in India let the Company present its new revenue power as legally derived and legitimate, even though that same emperor was, in practical terms, now a Company-protected pensioner with negligible independent power of his own.



Visual 13: The Treaty of Allahabad, 12 August 1765: two treaties, one day

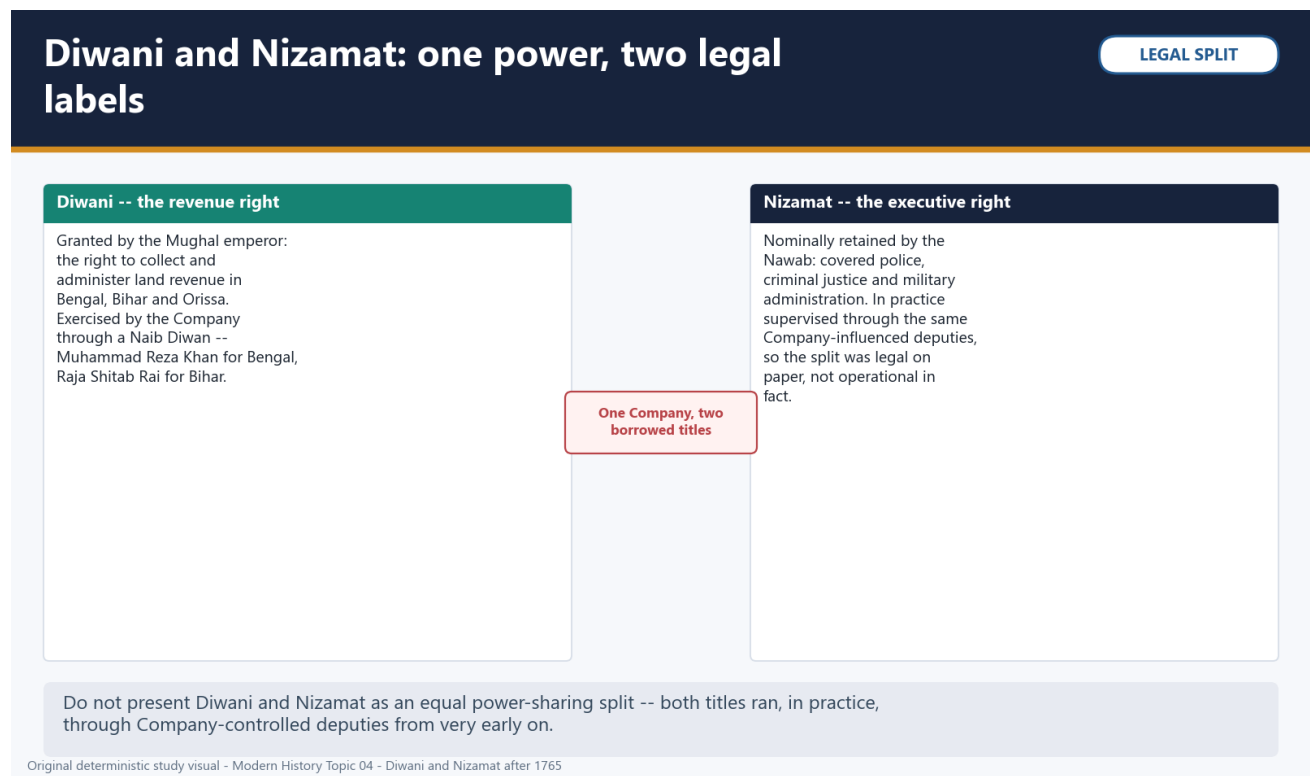
Visual 13: The Treaty of Allahabad, 12 August 1765: two treaties, one day. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

11. Diwani and Nizamat: one power, two legal labels

The Diwani grant requires careful legal precision, because it did not transfer the whole of Bengal's governing authority to the Company in one stroke. The Diwani -- granted by the Mughal emperor -- was specifically the right to collect and administer land revenue in Bengal, Bihar and Orissa; the Company exercised it through Naib Diwans, Muhammad Reza Khan for Bengal and Raja Shitab Rai for Bihar, rather than through direct Company officials in the first instance. The Nizamat -- covering police, criminal justice and military administration -- was nominally retained by the Nawab of Bengal.

FACT: in practice, both the Diwani and the Nizamat came to run through the same set of Company-influenced deputies from very early on, so the split between the two was real and legally meaningful on paper but not an equal or operationally independent division of power in fact. ANALYSIS: do not present Diwani and Nizamat as a genuine

fifty-fifty power-sharing arrangement between the Company and the Nawab -- the correct exam-safe formulation is that the Company held the substantively powerful revenue right directly, while nominal executive authority remained with a Nawab whose own capacity to exercise it independently was already hollowed out, a distinction that becomes the central subject of the Dual Government examined in Part VI.



Visual 14: Diwani and Nizamat: one power, two legal labels

Visual 14: Diwani and Nizamat: one power, two legal labels. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

PART VI - THE DUAL GOVERNMENT AND ITS COSTS

12. The Dual Government, 1765-72: Clive's design and its accountability paradox

Robert Clive, returning as Governor for a second term after Allahabad, deliberately chose not to have the Company assume direct, formal administration of Bengal in 1765. Instead he designed what came to be called the Dual Government: the Company held the Diwani and, through its Naib Diwans, the real revenue-collection and administrative power in Bengal, while the Nawab's government nominally retained the Nizamat -- answerability for law, order and criminal justice -- without the revenue or military resources needed to discharge that responsibility, since those now flowed through the Company's own deputies.

FACT: this arrangement was Clive's own deliberate design, not an accident of circumstance, and it produced what is best described as an accountability paradox -- the Company exercised real power while bearing no formal responsibility for Bengal's governance or welfare, while the Nawab's government bore nominal responsibility while holding no real power to act on it. **ANALYSIS:** this structure suited the Company's immediate interests precisely because it let it extract Bengal's revenue while avoiding the direct political and administrative costs -- and the international scrutiny -- that formal annexation would have invited, but it left no single accountable authority positioned to correct fiscal or administrative failure when one arose, a vulnerability the 1770 famine, examined next, exposed with particular clarity.

The clearest contemporary admission of the system's failure comes from Clive himself: testifying before the House of Commons in 1772, he stated that in Bengal "corruption universally prevails, and confusion and mismanagement pervade every department" -- a striking admission given that Clive had designed the very system he was describing. Warren Hastings, arriving as Governor in 1772, ended the Dual Government that year, having the Company itself

"stand forth as Diwan" and administer revenue directly rather than through Naib Diwans, formally closing the seven-year experiment Clive had created.

The Dual Government, 1765-72: an accountability paradox

PARADOX

The Company: power without responsibility

Held the Diwani and, through Naib Diwans, the real revenue and administrative power in Bengal -- but bore no formal accountability for justice, order or the population's welfare.

The Nawab's government: responsibility without power

Nominally still answerable for law and order under the Nizamat, but stripped of the revenue and military resources needed to discharge that responsibility.

Clive's own design, 1765-72

In 1772 Clive told Parliament that in Bengal 'corruption universally prevails, and confusion and mismanagement pervade every department.'

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - The Dual Government's accountability paradox, 1765-72

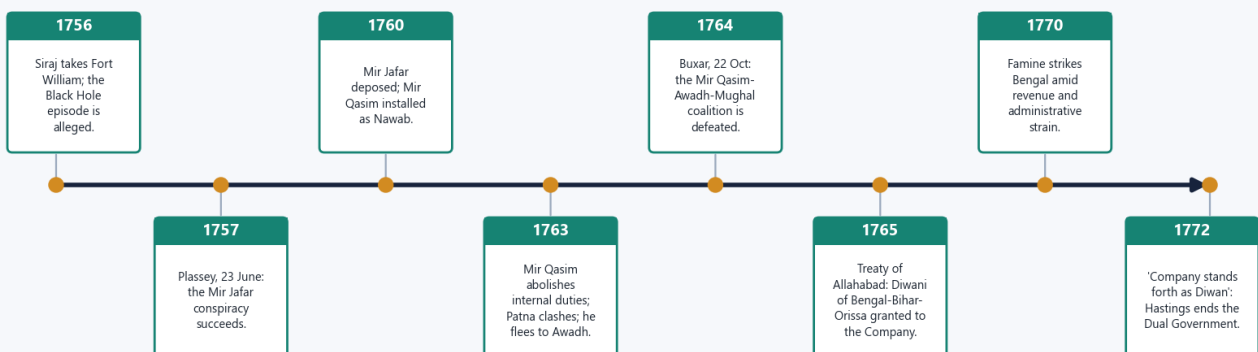
Visual 15: The Dual Government, 1765-72: an accountability paradox

Visual 15: The Dual Government, 1765-72: an accountability paradox. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Holding the full sixteen-year span in view -- from the Calcutta crisis of 1756 through Hastings's reform in 1772 -- is itself an examiner-tested skill: Prelims option-writing routinely tests precise sequencing across 1757, 1764, 1765, 1770 and 1772, and a candidate who can anchor each date to the specific decision it represents, not merely to "a battle" or "a treaty" in the abstract, is far better placed than one who has only memorised the names.

Master timeline: from the Calcutta crisis to the end of Dual Government

1756-1772



Sixteen years, five hinge dates: 1757, 1764, 1765, 1770 and 1772 are the ones examiners return to most often -- anchor each to one decision, not just one battle.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Master timeline, 1756-1772

Visual 16: Master timeline: from the Calcutta crisis to the end of Dual Government

Visual 16: Master timeline: from the Calcutta crisis to the end of Dual Government. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

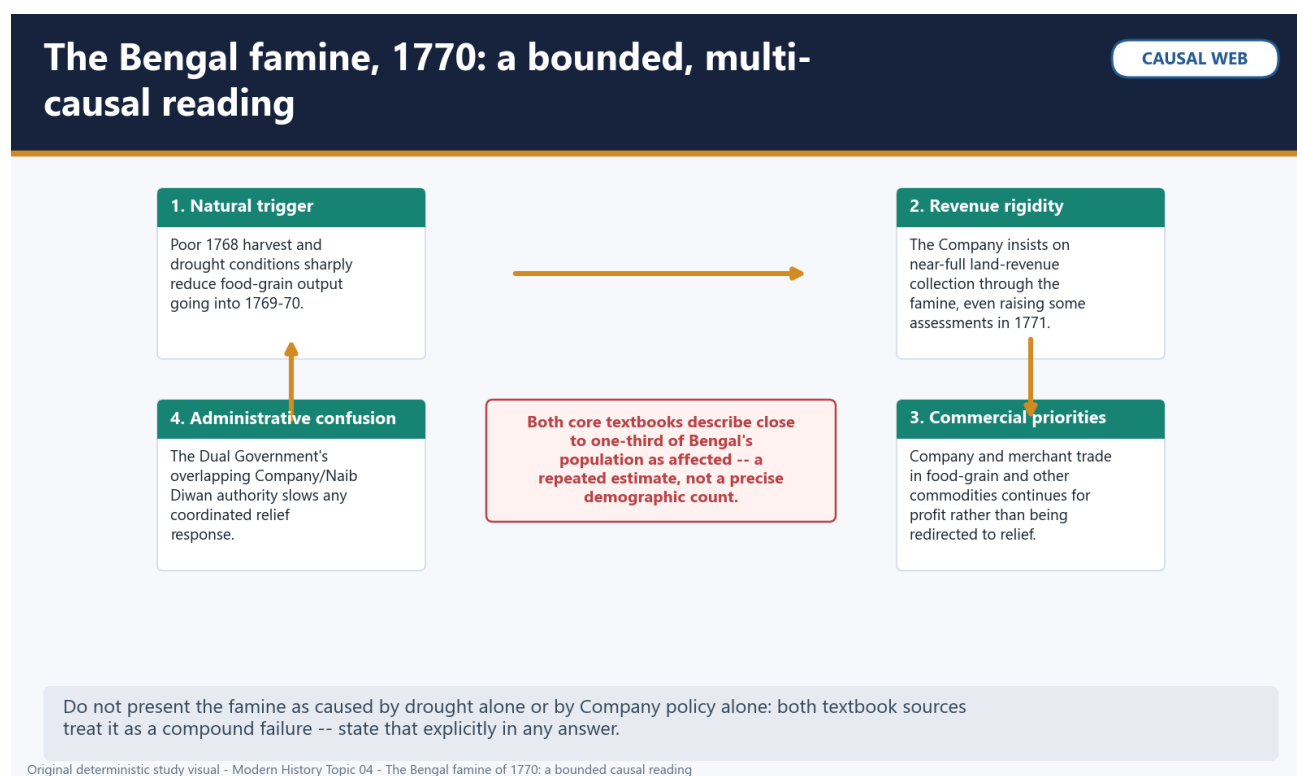
13. The Bengal famine of 1770: a bounded causal reading

The Bengal famine of 1770 struck during the Dual Government's operation and must be explained with a bounded, multi-causal framing rather than any single, monocausal claim. A poor 1768 harvest and drought conditions sharply reduced food-grain output heading into 1769-70 -- a genuine natural trigger that a defensible account cannot omit. But the famine's severity and the scale of suffering it produced cannot be explained by the natural trigger alone.

FACT: the Company continued to insist on near-full land-revenue collection through the famine, in some accounts even raising certain assessments in 1771, while Company and merchant trade in food-grain and other commodities continued to be conducted for commercial profit rather than being redirected toward relief; the Dual Government's own overlapping and unclear lines of Company and Naib Diwan authority further slowed any coordinated relief response.

ANALYSIS: both principal secondary accounts consulted for this package treat the famine as a compound failure -- a poor harvest meeting a fiscally rigid and administratively confused governance structure -- and that compound framing, not drought alone and not Company policy alone, is the defensible exam position; a monocausal answer in either direction should be marked down.

On the human cost, this package deliberately withholds any specific mortality figure as verified fact. Both core textbooks consulted here describe an estimate of roughly one-third of Bengal's population as affected, but this is a widely repeated estimate rather than a precise, census-based demographic count, and later colonial-era figures (such as those associated with W.W. Hunter's nineteenth-century account) are themselves historiographically disputed rather than officially audited. A defensible answer states the compound causal structure clearly, notes that contemporary and later estimates of scale exist without treating any single number as settled fact, and explicitly avoids fabricating precision the evidence does not support.



Visual 17: The Bengal famine, 1770: a bounded, multi-causal reading

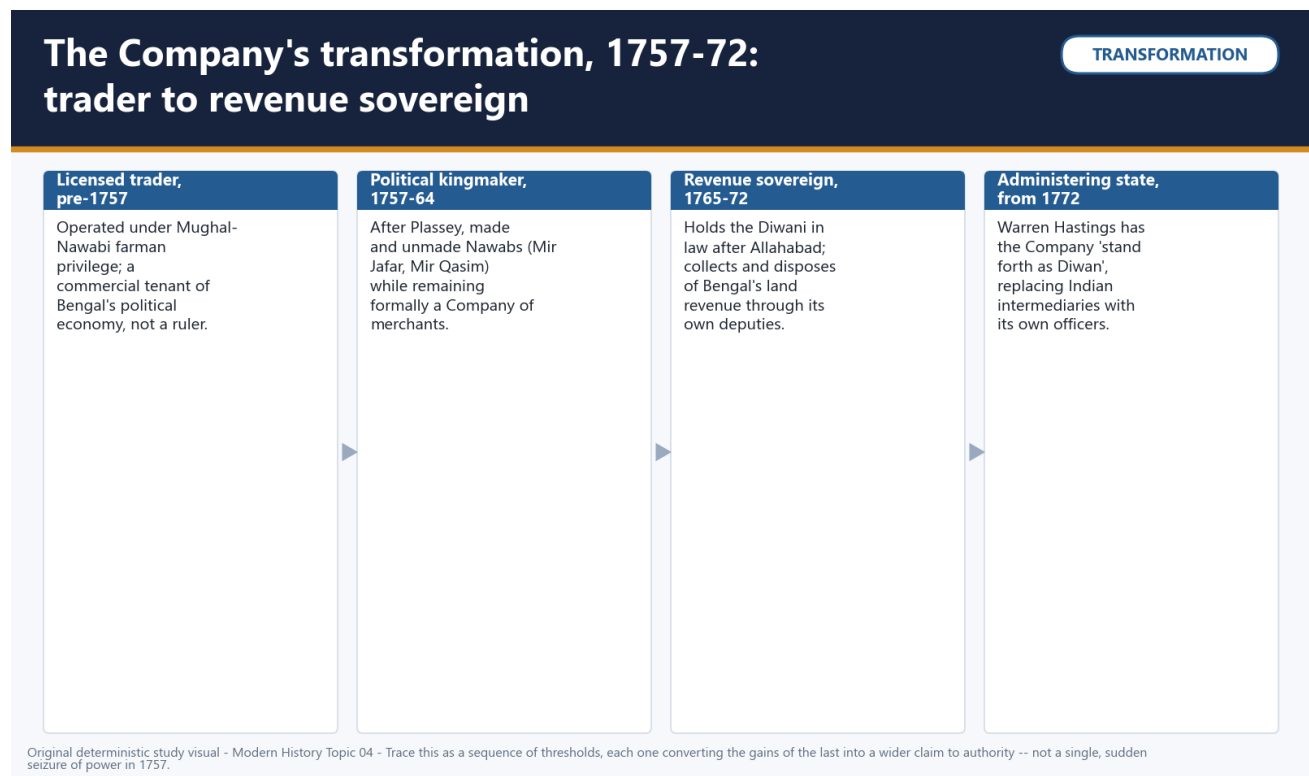
Visual 17: The Bengal famine, 1770: a bounded, multi-causal reading. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

PART VII - COMPANY, AGENCY AND HISTORIOGRAPHY

14. From trader to revenue sovereign: the Company's transformation and the spectrum of Indian agency

Tracing the Company's own transformation across this topic's sixteen-year span is itself a useful revision device. Before 1757 it operated as a licensed trader, holding Mughal-Nawabi farman privilege as a commercial tenant of Bengal's political economy, not a ruler. Between 1757 and 1764 it became a political kingmaker, making and unmaking Nawabs (Mir Jafar, then Mir Qasim) while remaining formally a company of merchants. From 1765 it became Bengal's revenue sovereign in law, holding the Diwani and collecting and disposing of land revenue through its own deputies. From 1772, under Hastings, it became an administering state outright, replacing Indian intermediaries with its own officers.

FACT: this is best understood as a sequence of thresholds, each converting the gains of the previous stage into a wider claim to authority, rather than a single, sudden seizure of power in 1757. ANALYSIS: framing the conquest this way directly counters the common exam trap of treating Plassey alone as "the conquest of Bengal" -- the Company's status changed qualitatively at each of at least four distinct points, and a strong Mains answer should be able to name the specific legal or institutional change (zamindari grant, Diwani grant, Hastings's reform) that marked each threshold rather than treating 1757-72 as one undifferentiated process.



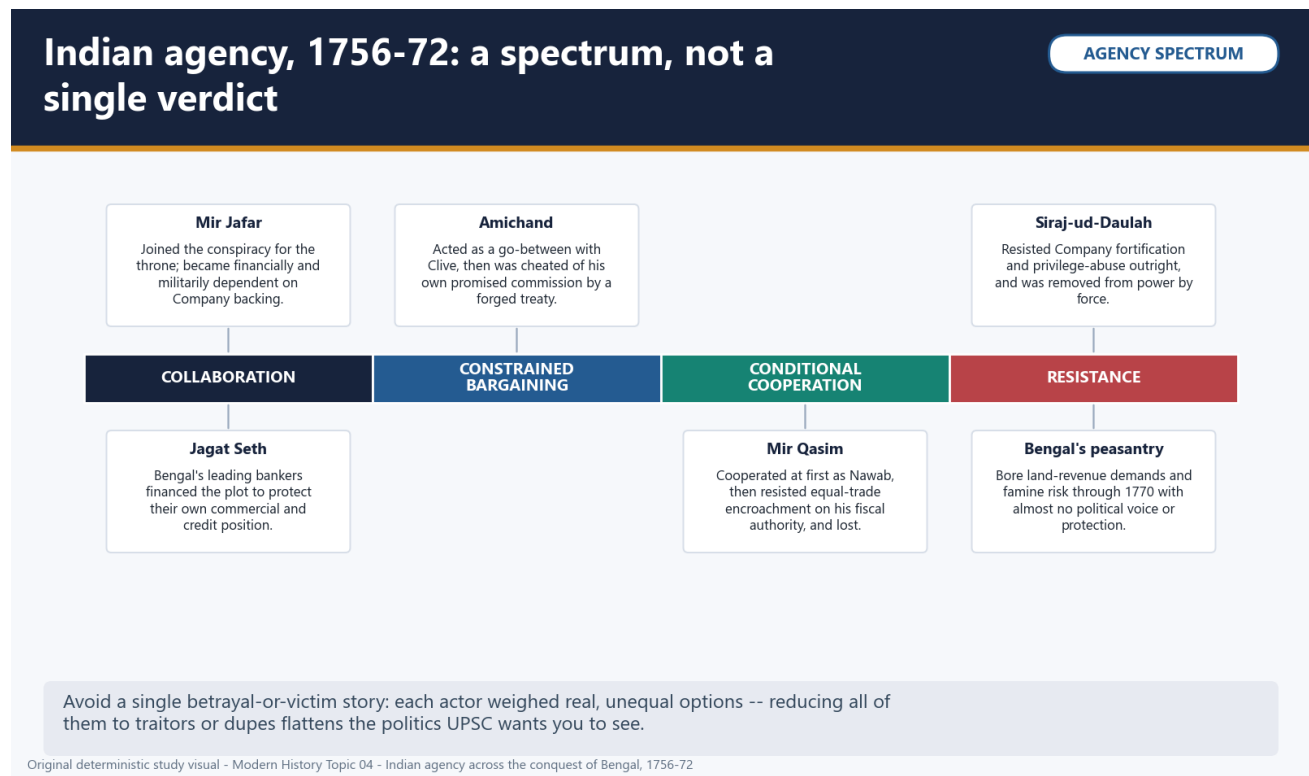
Visual 18: The Company's transformation, 1757-72: trader to revenue sovereign

Visual 18: The Company's transformation, 1757-72: trader to revenue sovereign. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

This transformation was not something the Company achieved alone, and Indian participants across the period occupied a genuine spectrum of positions rather than a single moral category of either collaborator or victim. Mir Jafar joined the conspiracy for the throne and became financially and militarily dependent on Company backing -- a case of collaboration. The Jagat Seths financed the plot to protect their own commercial and credit position -- collaboration for calculated institutional interest, not personal ambition alone. Amichand acted as a go-between with Clive and was then cheated of his own promised commission by a forged treaty -- a case of constrained bargaining that still ended in betrayal by the very party he had helped. Mir Qasim cooperated at first as Company-installed Nawab, then resisted equal-trade encroachment on his own fiscal authority and lost -- conditional cooperation giving way to resistance. Siraj-ud-Daulah resisted Company fortification and privilege-abuse outright from the start and was removed from power by force -- direct resistance. Bengal's peasantry, by contrast, bore land-revenue demands and famine risk

through 1770 with almost no political voice or protection at all.

FACT: reducing every one of these actors to either "traitor" or "dupe" flattens a set of genuinely different, unequally constrained choices into a single morality tale. **ANALYSIS:** the defensible exam position treats Indian agency across the conquest as a spectrum -- collaboration, constrained bargaining, conditional cooperation and resistance -- with each actor's position explicable by their own institutional interests and real (if unequal) options, not as a single verdict on "Indian character" or a simple story of European cunning defeating Indian innocence.



Visual 19: Indian agency, 1756-72: a spectrum, not a single verdict

Visual 19: Indian agency, 1756-72: a spectrum, not a single verdict. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

15. Reading the conquest: four historiographical lenses

Four historiographical lenses offer distinct, defensible ways of reading this topic's material, and naming the lens being used is itself an exam-earning move. The nationalist critique holds that Plassey and Buxar began a one-way economic drain; R.C. Dutt, as cited within Bipan Chandra's account, characterised the post-Plassey decades as a period of "open plunder and loot" -- a framing this package uses to explain post-Plassey extraction and the 1770 famine's fiscal backdrop, while leaving the full drain-of-wealth mechanics to Topic 07. The collaboration thesis holds that Indian elites -- bankers, zamindars, courtiers -- collaborated with the Company for their own local interests, not out of weakness, which explains directly why the Jagat Seths, Mir Jafar and Rai Durlabh joined the Plassey conspiracy. The corporate/fiscal-military state thesis, associated with historians including P.J. Marshall and C.A. Bayly, holds that the Company became a hybrid fiscal-military corporate state, continuous with earlier fiscal practice rather than a sudden rupture -- a lens that explains the Diwani grant and the Dual Government as an evolving revenue-military apparatus. A Bengal political-economy view, consistent with Sekhar Bandyopadhyay's account, emphasises that Bengal's own dense commercial and banking networks shaped how conquest and revenue extraction actually functioned on the ground, which explains the Jagat Seths' and Bengal's credit markets' central role throughout 1757-72.

FACT: these four lenses rest on different evidence bases and different emphases, not a single agreed narrative, and each is defensible when applied consistently. **ANALYSIS:** a strong Mains answer names the lens it is using explicitly -- "read through a nationalist lens" or "read through the collaboration thesis" -- and applies it consistently through the answer, rather than mixing incompatible framings within a single paragraph, which is precisely what examiners reward and what a mixed, unnamed framing forfeits.

Reading the conquest: four historiographical lenses

HISTORIOGRAPHY

	Core argument	How Topic 04 uses it
Nationalist critique	Plassey and Buxar began a one-way economic drain; R.C. Dutt (cited in Bipan Chandra) called the post-Plassey decades a period of 'open plunder and loot'	Explains post-Plassey extraction and the 1770 famine's fiscal backdrop; full drain mechanics belong to Topic 07
Collaboration thesis	Indian elites -- bankers, zamindars, courtiers -- collaborated for their own local interests, not out of weakness	Explains why Jagat Seth, Mir Jafar and Rai Durlabh joined the Plassey conspiracy
Corporate/fiscal-military state	The Company became a hybrid fiscal-military corporate state (P.J. Marshall, C.A. Bayly), continuous with earlier fiscalism	Explains the Diwani grant and Dual Government as an evolving revenue-military apparatus, not a sudden rupture
Bengal political-economy view	Bengal's own dense commercial and banking networks shaped how conquest and revenue extraction actually worked	Explains the central role of the Jagat Seths and Bengal's credit markets throughout 1757-72

Name the lens you are using in a Mains answer -- 'nationalist', 'collaboration' or 'corporate-state' framing each earns credit only when applied consistently, not mixed.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Four historiographical lenses on the conquest of Bengal

Visual 20: Reading the conquest: four historiographical lenses

Visual 20: Reading the conquest: four historiographical lenses. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

PART VIII - SYNTHESIS AND THE BRIDGE FORWARD

16. Comparative synthesis: Plassey, Buxar, Allahabad and the Dual Government, and the bridge forward

Bringing Plassey and Buxar into direct comparison sharpens exactly the causal-chain precision this topic tests most often. Plassey (1757) was a brief, one-sided skirmish decided mainly by a pre-arranged conspiracy, defeating a single Nawab with divided, half-loyal generals, under Clive's relatively small Company force reinforced from Madras; its mechanism was personal conspiracy and payment substituting for a real military contest, and its immediate outcome was Mir Jafar installed as a Company-dependent Nawab. Buxar (1764) was a harder-fought, more conventional pitched battle against a genuine three-part coalition -- a deposed Nawab, the Wazir of Awadh, and the Mughal emperor -- under Munro's unified force built on Bengal's post-Plassey resources; its mechanism was superior unified command defeating a larger but segmented coalition army, and its immediate outcome was the Treaty of Allahabad, granting the Diwani of Bengal-Bihar-Orissa to the Company.

FACT: Plassey made the Company Bengal's political kingmaker in practice; Buxar and Allahabad made the Company a recognised revenue-sovereign in law -- and it is this second, legal transformation that is the more strategically decisive of the two turning points. ANALYSIS: the recurring exam trap is treating Plassey as the whole story because it is the more famous name; a precise answer must be able to state which specific change followed from which specific event -- regime change from Plassey, legal revenue title from Allahabad -- and the Dual Government (1765-72) as the administrative structure that then converted that legal title into lived governance, however dysfunctionally, until Hastings ended it in 1772.

Topic boundaries: what Topic 04 does not re-teach

BOUNDARY MAP

Topic 03 owns

European Company beginnings and early trade rivalry before Bengal's political crisis -- assumed as background here, not repeated.

Topic 05 owns

Mysore, the Marathas, the Sikhs and the Company's broader 18th-19th century territorial expansion beyond Bengal.

Topic 06 owns

The constitutional structure of Company rule from the Regulating Act 1773 onward -- only bridged from here, not detailed.

Topic 07 owns

The full economic impact of British rule: the drain of wealth, de-industrialisation and land-revenue systems in depth.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Bounded bridge: Topic 04 ends at 1772; Regulating Act 1773 (Topic 06) and the fiscal/economic architecture it enabled (Topic 07) pick up from exactly this point.

Visual 21: Topic boundaries: what Topic 04 does not re-teach

Visual 21: Topic boundaries: what Topic 04 does not re-teach. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

This topic's own boundary is worth stating plainly, because a well-bounded answer earns more credit than an overreaching one. Topic 03 owns the European Company's early beginnings and trade rivalry before Bengal's political crisis, assumed here as background and not repeated. Topic 05 owns Mysore, the Marathas, the Sikhs and the Company's broader eighteenth- and nineteenth-century territorial expansion beyond Bengal; Buxar and the coalition's military detail are referenced here only as far as they explain the Bengal settlement, not as a full campaign history. Topic 06 owns the constitutional structure of Company rule from the Regulating Act of 1773 onward, bridged here only at the exact point -- 1772 -- where this topic's own narrative ends. Topic 07 owns the full economic impact of British rule -- the drain of wealth, de-industrialisation and land-revenue systems in depth -- of which this topic's post-Plassey extraction and famine material are only the opening, bounded chapter.

The bridge forward is therefore precise rather than open-ended: this topic's narrative closes in 1772, with Warren Hastings ending the Dual Government and the Company beginning to administer Bengal directly; the Regulating Act of 1773, which first subjected Company rule to parliamentary oversight, and the deeper economic architecture that Company rule then built on the foundation this topic describes, are Topics 06 and 07's material, picked up from exactly this point and not re-derived here.

PART IX - SOURCES, PYQ AUDIT AND PRACTICE

Transparent PYQ audit and route decision

Audit scope: every Prelims and Mains GS-I/GS-II/Essay routing ledger and integration-audit file currently in the repository, covering 2018 through 2026, was checked line by line for any question mentioning Murshid Quli Khan, Alivardi Khan, the 1717 farman or dastak abuse, Siraj-ud-Daulah, the Calcutta crisis or the Black Hole, the Plassey conspiracy or battle, Mir Jafar, Mir Qasim, Buxar, Shah Alam II, Shuja-ud-Daula, the Treaty of Allahabad, the Diwani/Nizamat split, the Dual Government, or the Bengal famine of 1770.

Audit result: PYQ- INTEGRATION-AUDIT-2018-2023 .md, PYQ- INTEGRATION-AUDIT-2024-2025 .md and PYQ- INTEGRATION-AUDIT-2026 .md each explicitly list Modern History Topic 04 (basic and advanced files alike) as owning no routed question across their respective windows. No Prelims or Mains question in any checked ledger, and no entry in either PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS or PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS ledger, is routed to Topic 04.

Workbook/session policy consequence: because this topic owns zero verified direct PYQs, this package does not fabricate a "Topic 04 PYQ list," and no official answer key is invented where none exists. Two thematically adjacent items only are used below, each with true ownership named explicitly, strictly as bounded bridge illustrations:

1. **2022 Mains GS-I, Q2**, 10 marks/150 words -- *"Why did the armies of the British East India Company -- mostly comprising of Indian soldiers -- win consistently against the more numerous and better equipped armies of the then Indian rulers? Give reasons."* This repository's own routing ledger (_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023 .md) stores only a neutral thematic rendering of this item ("East India Company armies winning against Indian rulers") and routes it to **Modern History Topic 05** (British Territorial Expansion), not to Topic 04; the fully verbatim wording quoted above was independently cross-checked against live official-paper sources for this package and is reproduced here only as a bounded forward-bridge illustration, since Topic 04's own account of segmented coalition command at Buxar (subtopic 9) is a relevant precondition to this question's theme, even though the specific multi-theatre military-fiscal mechanism the question tests belongs to Topic 05.
2. **2022 Mains GS-I, Q3**, 10 marks/150 words -- *"Why was there a sudden spurt in famines in colonial India since the mid-eighteenth century? Give reasons."* This repository's ledger again stores only a neutral paraphrase ("spurt in famines in colonial India since the mid-eighteenth century"); the verbatim wording above was likewise independently cross-checked for this package. It is routed to **Modern History Topic 07** (economic impact of British rule), and is referenced here only descriptively, as a thematic pointer toward the 1770 famine's place in a longer colonial pattern -- never claimed as Topic 04's own question, and not developed here into a full solved answer.

Adjacent evidence is not substitution: an adjacent item illustrates a related theme; it is never claimed as "this topic's own question," and a candidate should not cite either item in an answer as if Topic 04 itself were the question's subject. No further PYQ is claimed for this topic. Where this package's own original MCQs and Mains questions appear below, they are clearly original practice material, not represented as previous UPSC questions, and any answer without a locally verified official key is explicitly labelled **INFERRED ANSWER -- NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED**.

Evidence and answer-writing drills

The 1717 farman and the dastak: privilege vs abuse

PRELIMS-CRITICAL

The Company's privilege (1717 Farrukhsiyar farman)

Duty-free import/export of the COMPANY's own registered goods in Bengal; the right to issue dastak passes certifying such cargo; built on the 1690s Aurangzeb-era concession and Calcutta's earlier zamindari and fortification rights.

Servants' private-trade abuse (what Nawabs actually contested)

Company servants privately sold or misused dastaks to cover their own and Indian agents' private trade, evading duties that Indian merchants still had to pay in full. Murshid Quli Khan, Alivardi Khan and Siraj-ud-Daulah all resisted this extension.

Same instrument, two rival claims: this exact separation is what Prelims tests.

Do not conflate the 1717 privilege (real, treaty-based, Company-only) with servants' dastak abuse (an unauthorised extension no Nawab accepted) -- examiners reward exactly this split.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Farman and dastak: privilege vs abuse

Visual 2: Repeat: the farman-vs-dastak-abuse distinction, previewed before the drills below

Visual 2: Repeat: the farman-vs-dastak-abuse distinction, previewed before the drills below. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Drill 1 - The 1717 farman is not the same claim as dastak abuse

Claim: Write the 1717 Farrukhsiyar farman as a real, treaty-based, Company-only duty exemption; write servants' dastak misuse as a separate, unauthorised extension that Murshid Quli Khan, Alivardi Khan and Siraj-ud-Daulah all resisted. Never merge the two into one generic "trade privilege."

Exam move: Prelims statement-pairs on this period are built almost entirely around this exact split -- answer by testing whether a statement describes the 1717 grant itself or servants' abuse of it, not by recalling the year alone.

Drill 2 - The Black Hole is a source-criticism question, not a body-count question

Claim: Name Holwell as a single interested narrator, note the absence of independent corroboration, and mention the episode's own later contested memory (the 1940 campaign against the Holwell monument) as part of the answer, not a footnote.

Exam move: If a question asks you to "discuss" the Black Hole, spend as many words on why the evidence is disputed as on what is alleged to have happened -- a answer that states a specific death toll as settled fact has already lost marks before reaching its conclusion.

Drill 3 - Plassey is a coup question, even when it is asked as a battle question

Claim: Whatever the question's wording, describe Plassey's decisive mechanism as the pre-arranged conspiracy (Mir Jafar, Jagat Seth, Rai Durlabh, Amichand), with real fighting confined to Mir Madan's and Mohan Lal's small loyal wing.

Exam move: If a question asks "how was Plassey won," the expected answer is political, not tactical; a purely military description of troop movements, without the conspiracy, answers a different and less accurate question.

Drill 4 - Hold casualty figures loosely, and say so explicitly

Claim: Cite the traditional figures (around 29 Company dead against several hundred, often given as close to 500, on Siraj's side) only as textbook figures, explicitly flagged as such, not as precisely audited modern casualty counts.

Exam move: Add a short qualifying clause -- "figures traditionally cited in general accounts" -- whenever a casualty number appears in an answer; this single habit protects against being marked down for false precision.

Drill 5 - Post-Plassey extraction is a circuit, not a bribe

Claim: Describe Mir Jafar's payments, Clive's personal fortune and the 24-Parganas zamindari grant as a self-reinforcing circuit -- dependence produces payment, payment deepens dependence -- ending in Mir Jafar's own deposition in 1760 once he could not sustain it.

Exam move: A "why was Mir Jafar deposed" question is answered by this circuit, not by a single act of defiance on his part; keep this subtopic's material bounded to 1757-60 and hand the wider drain-of-wealth analysis to Topic 07 rather than re-deriving it here.

Drill 6 - Mir Qasim wanted equal taxation, not simply to expel the Company

Claim: State his 1763 abolition of internal duties as aimed at equal treatment for Indian and European merchants alike; treat Company hostility to this measure as the consequence of lost tax advantage, not evidence that Mir Qasim was primarily an anti-colonial nationalist in the modern sense.

Exam move: A question inviting a character assessment of Mir Qasim rewards naming his specific administrative aims (Munger, army reform, equal duties) before any conflict narrative, not the reverse order.

Drill 7 - Buxar's coalition lost to structure, not to a lack of courage

Claim: Explain the coalition's defeat through its own segmented command -- three treasuries, three commanders, no shared war-chest -- against Munro's single unified chain of command, rather than through any claim about troop quality or morale.

Exam move: If a question invites comparison between Plassey and Buxar's military character, lead with command structure, not troop numbers -- numbers favoured the coalition; structure did not.

Drill 8 - State precisely which event changed what

Claim: Attribute regime change (a new Nawab) to Plassey, and the Company's legal revenue title to Buxar plus the Treaty of Allahabad; never credit Plassey alone with establishing Company sovereignty in Bengal.

Exam move: Any answer beginning "the British conquered Bengal at Plassey in 1757" without qualification has already made the single most common factual overreach on this topic; add "politically" after "conquered" or replace the sentence with the Plassey-then-Buxar-then-Allahabad sequence.

Drill 9 - Two treaties at Allahabad did two different jobs

Claim: Name the Shah Alam II treaty as the source of the Diwani grant and the Shuja-ud-Daula treaty as the separate Awadh-restoration settlement, both signed 12 August 1765; never describe "the Treaty of Allahabad" as a single undifferentiated document.

Exam move: A Prelims option that says "the Treaty of Allahabad restored Awadh to Shuja-ud-Daula and granted the Diwani to the Company" is correct only if you recognise it is quietly describing two instruments as one -- true in combined outcome, imprecise in legal form.

Drill 10 - Diwani and Nizamat were not an equal split

Claim: State that the Company held the substantively powerful Diwani directly through its own Naib Diwans, while the Nawab's Nizamat was nominal and, in practice, exercised through the same Company-influenced deputies.

Exam move: Reject any statement describing 1765-72 Bengal as "jointly ruled" by the Company and the Nawab on genuinely equal terms; the correct formulation is one substantive power-holder and one nominal title-holder, which is exactly the Dual Government's own internal paradox.

Drill 11 - Name the Dual Government's paradox in both directions

Claim: State both halves explicitly -- Company power without formal responsibility, Nawab's government responsibility without real power -- rather than describing only one side of the arrangement.

Exam move: A 15-mark "why did the Dual Government fail" answer that names only Company misrule, or only the Nawab's weakness, has described half the mechanism; both halves together are what "failed by design" means here.

Drill 12 - The 1770 famine takes two causes, stated together, never one

Claim: Pair the natural trigger (poor 1768 harvest, 1769-70 drought) with the governance vulnerability (revenue rigidity, commercial priorities, Dual Government administrative confusion) in the same sentence; never present drought or Company policy as a sufficient standalone cause.

Exam move: Do not state a specific famine mortality figure as verified fact; if scale must be mentioned, attribute it explicitly as a repeated secondary-source estimate, not a census result.

Drill 13 - Indian actors chose within constraints; they were not simply traitors or dupes

Claim: Place each named actor (Mir Jafar, Jagat Seth, Amichand, Mir Qasim, Siraj-ud-Daulah, Bengal's peasantry) on the collaboration-to-resistance spectrum with their own institutional motive stated, rather than collapsing all of them into a single moral verdict.

Exam move: An answer that uses the word "betrayal" as its entire explanatory mechanism has substituted a moral label for an analytical one; name the specific interest (credit protection, personal ambition, fiscal parity) instead.

Drill 14 - Never invent a PYQ, an official key, or a topic boundary

Claim: This topic owns zero routed PYQs, per the repository's own three integration audits; any adjacent item used must carry its true owning topic explicitly, and any answer without a locally verified official key must be labelled INFERRED ANSWER -- NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED.

Exam move: When a question edges toward Topics 03, 05, 06 or 07's material, state the boundary explicitly ("this is [Topic]'s material") rather than either refusing to engage or silently absorbing that topic's content as if it were Topic 04's own.

Learning MCQs (20; key rotation A -> B -> C -> D repeated five times)

Correct options are deliberately rotated by actual option placement, not by relabelling: A -> B -> C -> D through the full set. Read the explanation after attempting each item.

Plassey: a political coup, not a conventional military triumph

COUP vs BATTLE

	What a conventional triumph would show	What actually happened at Plassey
Force ratio	Nawab's nominal army was several times the size of the Company's force	Numbers barely mattered once the largest wings had agreed not to fight
Actual fighting	A full day's pitched battle across both armies on an open field	Real combat was confined to Mir Madan and Mohan Lal's small loyal wing
Decisive factor	Superior generalship or firepower deciding an open contest	A pre-arranged conspiracy involving Mir Jafar, Jagat Seth, Rai Durlabh and Amichand
Casualties	Heavy losses on both sides matching the scale of the armies engaged	English losses were 29; the Nawab's side lost nearly 500 -- a lopsided, short affair
Outcome secured by	Battlefield victory alone deciding who would rule Bengal next	Prior letters, bribes, and the promise of the throne to Mir Jafar
What changed	A single day's military result and nothing more	A change of regime: Mir Jafar as Nawab, the Company as Bengal's political kingmaker

Exam framing: describe Plassey as a negotiated transfer of power validated by a brief skirmish -- not as a hard-fought battlefield victory that happened to change the throne.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Plassey as political coup vs conventional battle

Visual 7: Repeat: Plassey as coup, not conventional battle, previewed before Learning MCQs

Visual 7: Repeat: Plassey as coup, not conventional battle, previewed before Learning MCQs. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Q1. What did the 1717 Farrukhsiyar farman actually grant the English East India Company in Bengal?

- A. Duty-free import and export of the Company's own registered goods, certified by dastak passes
- B. A permanent exemption from internal transit duties for any merchant carrying a Company employee's personal letter
- C. Full zamindari and revenue-collection rights over Murshidabad and its surrounding parganas
- D. The right to maintain an armed garrison at Murshidabad itself

Answer: A. Duty-free import and export of the Company's own registered goods, certified by dastak passes

Explanation: The farman was a bounded, Company-only commercial privilege; the other options describe things no Nawab ever granted, or things that mimic servants' later dastak abuse rather than the farman's actual terms.

Q2. Which of the following correctly describes resistance to dastak abuse before 1757?

- A. Only Siraj-ud-Daulah objected to it; Murshid Quli Khan and Alivardi Khan tolerated it as a cost of trade
- B. Murshid Quli Khan, Alivardi Khan and Siraj-ud-Daulah all resisted the unauthorised extension of dastak privileges by Company servants
- C. The Mughal emperor personally revoked the 1717 farman once abuse was reported
- D. Dastak abuse was permanently resolved by the Treaty of Alinagar in 1757

Answer: B. Murshid Quli Khan, Alivardi Khan and Siraj-ud-Daulah all resisted the unauthorised extension of dastak privileges by Company servants

Explanation: All three successive Nawabs objected to the same unauthorised extension; the farman was never revoked, and Alinagar addressed the Calcutta crisis of 1756-57, not dastak abuse specifically.

Q3. Why did Siraj-ud-Daulah march on Calcutta in June 1756?

- A. To seize the Company's textile monopoly at Dhaka
- B. In direct retaliation for the Black Hole incident
- C. Because the English refused to stop unauthorised fortification of Fort William and dismantle existing works
- D. To pre-empt a French attack on Chandernagore

Answer: C. Because the English refused to stop unauthorised fortification of Fort William and dismantle existing works

Explanation: The fortification dispute was the proximate cause; the Black Hole is alleged to have occurred only after Calcutta fell, so it cannot have caused the march, and Chandernagore was seized by the Company later, not attacked by the French first.

Q4. Why did Clive and Watson seize the French factory at Chandernagore in March 1757, before any confrontation with Siraj-ud-Daulah?

- A. Because Chandernagore had itself attacked Fort William in 1756
- B. On the direct written order of Mir Jafar
- C. Because the 1717 farman entitled the Company to seize rival European factories during wartime
- D. To remove Siraj's potential French counterweight while the Plassey conspiracy was maturing

Answer: D. To remove Siraj's potential French counterweight while the Plassey conspiracy was maturing

Explanation: This was a calculated pre-emptive move tied to the wider Anglo-French war and the developing Plassey conspiracy; no such Chandernagore attack, farman clause, or Mir Jafar directive existed.

Q5. What is the principal source-critical problem with the Holwell account of the 'Black Hole of Calcutta'?

- A. It rests on a single interested narrator with no independently corroborated casualty count
- B. It was written by an anonymous Bengali chronicler with no connection to the Company
- C. It was independently verified by three separate Company officials before publication
- D. Modern forensic examination of the Fort William guardroom has settled the exact death toll

Answer: A. It rests on a single interested narrator with no independently corroborated casualty count

Explanation: Holwell was himself a Company official and survivor with a strong personal stake in the story; no independent corroboration or forensic settlement of numbers exists, which is exactly why the episode must be treated as disputed.

Q6. Which of the following was NOT part of the 1757 Plassey conspiracy network?

- A. Mir Jafar, Siraj-ud-Daulah's own Mir Bakshi
- B. Shuja-ud-Daula, the Nawab-Wazir of Awadh
- C. The Jagat Seth banking house
- D. Rai Durlabh, Bengal's Diwan

Answer: B. Shuja-ud-Daula, the Nawab-Wazir of Awadh

Explanation: Shuja-ud-Daula joined the later Buxar coalition of 1764, seven years after Plassey; he had no role in the 1757 conspiracy against Siraj-ud-Daulah.

Q7. What was the 'red treaty' deception in the Plassey conspiracy?

- A. A secret treaty in which Mir Jafar promised Bengal's Diwani to the Mughal emperor
- B. A false peace treaty shown to Siraj-ud-Daulah to delay his mobilisation
- C. A fraudulent copy of the conspiracy treaty carrying a commission clause for Amichand, with Admiral Watson's signature forged onto it after he refused to sign
- D. The genuine treaty version that was later honoured in full after Plassey

Answer: C. A fraudulent copy of the conspiracy treaty carrying a commission clause for Amichand, with Admiral Watson's signature forged onto it after he refused to sign

Explanation: Clive prepared a genuine white-paper treaty without any Amichand clause and a fraudulent red-paper version with a forged Watson signature, deceiving his own co-conspirator, not Siraj or the emperor.

Q8. Which best describes the decisive mechanism at the Battle of Plassey, 23 June 1757?

- A. Superior Company artillery overwhelmed a numerically smaller Nawabi force
- B. A full day's pitched battle, evenly matched, was turned by a late cavalry charge
- C. Naval bombardment from Company ships on the Hooghly river decided the outcome
- D. A pre-arranged political conspiracy had already neutralised most of Siraj's army before serious fighting began

Answer: D. A pre-arranged political conspiracy had already neutralised most of Siraj's army before serious fighting began

Explanation: Mir Jafar's and Rai Durlabh's wings, the bulk of Siraj's nominal strength, had a prior understanding with Clive and never engaged; the conspiracy, not artillery, naval power or a cavalry charge, was decisive.

Q9. At Plassey, which two commanders led the only wing that fought hard for Siraj-ud-Daulah?

- A. Mir Madan and Mohan Lal
- B. Mir Jafar and Rai Durlabh
- C. Amichand and Jagat Seth
- D. Shuja-ud-Daula and Mir Qasim

Answer: A. Mir Madan and Mohan Lal

Explanation: Mir Madan and Mohan Lal's wing fought a genuine artillery duel; Mir Jafar and Rai Durlabh were the conspirators who withheld their forces, and the remaining names had no battlefield command role at Plassey.

Q10. What territorial or fiscal concession did Mir Jafar grant the Company immediately after Plassey, beyond cash compensation?

- A. The Diwani of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa
- B. The zamindari of the 24 Parganas near Calcutta
- C. Duty-free trade throughout the entire Mughal empire
- D. The fortress and district of Munger

Answer: B. The zamindari of the 24 Parganas near Calcutta

Explanation: The Diwani came only in 1765 via the Treaty of Allahabad; the 24-Parganas zamindari grant is the correct 1757 concession, well before any Diwani existed.

Q11. Why was Mir Jafar deposed by the Company in 1760?

- A. He refused to pay any compensation after Plassey
- B. He allied openly with the French at Chandernagore
- C. He could no longer meet the Company's escalating fresh financial demands, driven partly by its regional military commitments
- D. He abolished internal transit duties, angering Company traders

Answer: C. He could no longer meet the Company's escalating fresh financial demands, driven partly by its regional military commitments

Explanation: The duty-abolition measure (the fourth option) describes Mir Qasim's later 1763 reform, not Mir Jafar's; Mir Jafar's actual failure was fiscal exhaustion under continuing Company demands.

Q12. Why did Mir Qasim shift his capital from Murshidabad to Munger after 1760?

- A. Munger was closer to the Mughal emperor's court at Delhi
- B. Murshidabad had been destroyed in the Calcutta crisis fighting
- C. The Jagat Seths refused to extend him further credit at Murshidabad
- D. To gain distance from Calcutta's overbearing influence while positioning himself closer to his own recruits and revenue base

Answer: D. To gain distance from Calcutta's overbearing influence while positioning himself closer to his own recruits and revenue base

Explanation: The move to Munger (Monghyr) in Bihar was a deliberate assertion of administrative and military independence from Company oversight, not a response to any of the other listed events.

Q13. What was Mir Qasim's stated aim in abolishing internal transit duties in 1763?

- A. Equal, uniform taxation for Indian and European merchants alike
- B. To raise additional revenue for his own treasury by taxing all trade at a higher combined rate
- C. To punish Indian merchants who had collaborated with the Company
- D. To comply with a direct order from the Mughal emperor Shah Alam II

Answer: A. Equal, uniform taxation for Indian and European merchants alike

Explanation: Mir Qasim's measure removed duties rather than raising them; its explicit aim was competitive parity between Indian and European traders, not revenue-raising, favouritism, or imperial instruction.

Q14. Which three parties formed the coalition defeated at the Battle of Buxar in 1764?

- A. Mir Jafar, the Jagat Seths and Rai Durlabh
- B. Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II
- C. Siraj-ud-Daulah, Amichand and Mir Madan
- D. Warren Hastings, Muhammad Reza Khan and Raja Shitab Rai

Answer: B. Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II

Explanation: The first option names 1757 Plassey conspirators; the third mixes a Nawab already dead by 1764 with Plassey-era figures; the fourth names Dual Government-era administrators from after 1765, not the 1764 coalition.

Q15. What was the principal reason the Buxar coalition lost to a numerically smaller Company force?

- A. The coalition lacked artillery of any kind
- B. Shah Alam II refused to commit any troops to the battle
- C. The coalition's segmented command -- three separate treasuries and commanders with no shared war-chest -- could not match the Company's single unified chain of command
- D. Heavy monsoon rains disabled the coalition's cavalry

Answer: C. The coalition's segmented command -- three separate treasuries and commanders with no shared war-chest -- could not match the Company's single unified chain of command

Explanation: The coalition did field a large combined force with artillery and committed troops from all three partners; its structural weakness was divided, mutually distrustful command, not equipment, troop refusal or weather.

Q16. Which statement correctly distinguishes what Plassey changed from what Buxar and Allahabad changed?

- A. Plassey granted the Diwani; Buxar merely confirmed Mir Jafar as Nawab
- B. Both events achieved identical outcomes and can be treated as a single turning point
- C. Buxar changed who sat on Bengal's throne; Plassey created the Company's legal revenue title
- D. Plassey changed who sat on the throne; Buxar and Allahabad created the Company's legal revenue title, the more decisive change

Answer: D. Plassey changed who sat on the throne; Buxar and Allahabad created the Company's legal revenue title, the more decisive change

Explanation: The fourth option states the correct, examiner-tested sequence; the first and third options reverse the actual causal order, and the second collapses a distinction the exam specifically tests.

Q17. The two treaties signed at Allahabad on 12 August 1765 did which two distinct things?

- A. One granted the Company the Diwani of Bengal-Bihar-Orissa from Shah Alam II; the other restored Awadh to Shuja-ud-Daula in exchange for an indemnity
- B. Both treaties jointly restored the full Mughal empire's real authority over Bengal
- C. One treaty abolished the Nizamat outright; the other created the Dual Government
- D. One treaty ended the Bengal famine response; the other began the Regulating Act process

Answer: A. One granted the Company the Diwani of Bengal-Bihar-Orissa from Shah Alam II; the other restored Awadh to Shuja-ud-Daula in exchange for an indemnity

Explanation: The Diwani grant and the Awadh restoration were the two real 1765 instruments; the Nizamat was not abolished (it continued nominally), and the famine (1770) and Regulating Act (1773) are later, unrelated events.

Q18. Which statement most accurately describes the Diwani-Nizamat split after 1765?

- A. The Company and the Nawab shared power on genuinely equal terms, each fully independent in their own domain
- B. The Company held the substantively powerful Diwani through its own Naib Diwans, while the Nawab's Nizamat was nominal and, in practice, ran through the same Company-influenced deputies
- C. The Nizamat was more powerful than the Diwani because it covered military affairs
- D. The Diwani and Nizamat were merged into a single office in 1765 and separated again only in 1772

Answer: B. The Company held the substantively powerful Diwani through its own Naib Diwans, while the Nawab's Nizamat was nominal and, in practice, ran through the same Company-influenced deputies

Explanation: The split was legally real but operationally unequal from very early on; describing it as equal power-sharing or as a merged office both misstate the arrangement, and revenue collection was the more consequential power in practice.

Q19. The Dual Government's 'accountability paradox' refers to which arrangement?

- A. Both the Company and the Nawab held equal formal responsibility for Bengal's welfare
- B. Neither the Company nor the Nawab held any responsibility for Bengal at all
- C. The Company held real power without formal responsibility, while the Nawab's government held nominal responsibility without real power
- D. The Nawab held real power while the Company held only ceremonial status

Answer: C. The Company held real power without formal responsibility, while the Nawab's government held nominal responsibility without real power

Explanation: This is Clive's own 1765 design, named directly in his 1772 testimony about pervasive 'confusion and mismanagement'; the other options each misstate which side held power versus responsibility.

Q20. Which is the most defensible causal framing of the Bengal famine of 1770?

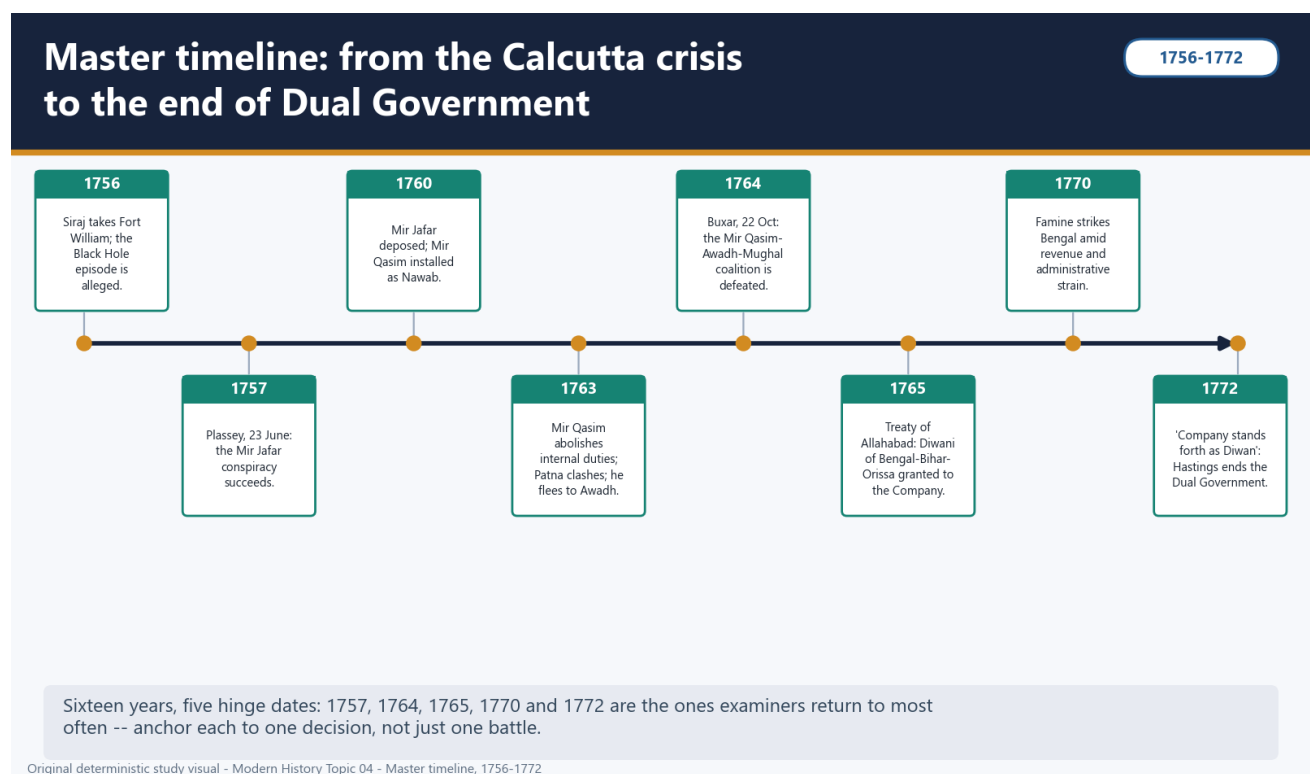
- A. The famine was caused solely by the 1768-69 drought, with no governance factor involved
- B. The famine was caused solely by Company revenue policy, with no natural trigger involved
- C. The famine's mortality is settled precisely at one-third of Bengal's population by official census record
- D. The famine resulted from a poor harvest and drought meeting a fiscally rigid, administratively confused Dual Government -- a compound failure, not a single cause

Answer: D. The famine resulted from a poor harvest and drought meeting a fiscally rigid, administratively confused Dual Government -- a compound failure, not a single cause

Explanation: Both core secondary sources consulted treat the famine as compound causation; the first two options each assert an unsupportable monocausal claim, and the third fabricates census-level precision that does not exist for this event.

Broad MCQs (44; key rotation A -> B -> C -> D repeated eleven times)

These questions cover nearly every subtopic in the package at greater depth, including figures, sequencing and named historiographical positions.



Visual 16: Repeat: the master timeline, previewed before the date- and sequence-heavy Broad MCQs

Visual 16: Repeat: the master timeline, previewed before the date- and sequence-heavy Broad MCQs. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Q21. Which term describes Murshid Quli Khan's method of assigning revenue collection to the highest bidder, later criticised for encouraging short-term extraction over long-term agrarian investment?

- A. Ijaradari (revenue farming)
- B. Zamindari settlement
- C. Ryotwari settlement
- D. Permanent Settlement

Answer: A. Ijaradari (revenue farming)

Explanation: Ijaradari was Murshid Quli Khan's own method; the other three are different revenue systems from later, mostly post-1793 Company administration, not his Bengal.

Q22. Two different battles at a place called Giria appear in this topic's timeline. Which pairing is correct?

- A. Alivardi Khan's 1740 Giria victory was against the Company; Mir Qasim's 1763 Giria defeat was against Shuja-ud-Daula
- B. Alivardi Khan's 1740 Giria victory was over Sarfaraz Khan for the Nawabship; Mir Qasim's 1763 Giria defeat was against the Company during his own conflict
- C. Both Giria battles were fought by the same person, twenty-three years apart
- D. Giria refers to a single 1757 battle also known as Plassey

Answer: B. Alivardi Khan's 1740 Giria victory was over Sarfaraz Khan for the Nawabship; Mir Qasim's 1763 Giria defeat was against the Company during his own conflict

Explanation: These are two separate battles at the same place name, 23 years apart, involving different combatants and different stakes; year-anchoring, not the place name alone, distinguishes them.

Q23. Which of these is the clearest example of individual servant abuse, as distinct from the Company's own chartered privilege?

- A. The Company's tax-free trade in its own registered goods under the 1717 farman
- B. The Company's right to fortify Fort William under its original settlement terms
- C. A private Company servant using a personal dastak to move his own unregistered goods duty-free, for personal profit
- D. The Company's right to mint coinage after 1765

Answer: C. A private Company servant using a personal dastak to move his own unregistered goods duty-free, for personal profit

Explanation: This is precisely the abuse pattern Nawabs objected to -- a personal privilege stretched beyond its authorised, Company-only, registered-goods scope; the other options describe genuine institutional or later authorised rights.

Q24. The immediate trigger for the 1756 Calcutta crisis was a dispute over which issue?

- A. Non-payment of the 26-lakh Diwani tribute
- B. Company recognition of Mir Jafar as Nawab
- C. Abolition of internal transit duties
- D. Unauthorised strengthening of Fort William's defences against the Nawab's explicit instruction

Answer: D. Unauthorised strengthening of Fort William's defences against the Nawab's explicit instruction

Explanation: The other options belong to later periods entirely (the 1765 Diwani grant, the 1757 Plassey settlement, and Mir Qasim's 1763 reform); the 1756 crisis was specifically about fortification.

Q25. Which Company factory fell to Siraj-ud-Daulah's forces in June 1756, before Fort William itself was attacked?

- A. Kasimbazar
- B. Chandernagore
- C. Munger
- D. Patna

Answer: A. Kasimbazar

Explanation: Kasimbazar, the Company's up-country factory near Murshidabad, was seized first; Chandernagore was a French factory seized later by the Company itself, and Munger/Patna belong to Mir Qasim's later career.

Q26. On which date did Fort William, Calcutta, fall to Siraj-ud-Daulah's forces in 1756?

- A. 2 January 1757
- B. 20 June 1756
- C. 23 June 1757
- D. 12 August 1765

Answer: B. 20 June 1756

Explanation: Fort William fell on 20 June 1756; 2 January 1757 is Clive/Watson's recapture, 23 June 1757 is Plassey, and 12 August 1765 is the Treaty of Allahabad.

Q27. What happened to the Holwell monument commemorating the 'Black Hole' victims in 1940?

- A. It was expanded into a full memorial museum by the colonial government
- B. It was relocated to Fort William's parade ground for the first time
- C. It was removed from its central Calcutta location amid nationalist campaigning that questioned the episode's contested memory
- D. It was declared a protected heritage monument by the Archaeological Survey of India

Answer: C. It was removed from its central Calcutta location amid nationalist campaigning that questioned the episode's contested memory

Explanation: The 1940 removal, linked to nationalist agitation, reflects exactly the episode's disputed and politically charged historical memory, not commemorative expansion or heritage recognition.

Q28. The Treaty of Alinagar, February 1757, achieved which outcome?

- A. It granted the Company the Diwani of Bengal
- B. It formally deposed Siraj-ud-Daulah
- C. It ended the Anglo-French rivalry in Bengal permanently
- D. It restored the Company's Calcutta privileges and compensated its losses, temporarily settling the crisis before Plassey

Answer: D. It restored the Company's Calcutta privileges and compensated its losses, temporarily settling the crisis before Plassey

Explanation: Alinagar was a temporary settlement following the Fort William recapture; the Diwani (1765) and Siraj's deposition (Plassey, June 1757) both came later, and Anglo-French rivalry continued well beyond 1757.

Q29. What was the strategic significance of the Company's capture of French Chandernagore in March 1757?

- A. It removed Siraj-ud-Daulah's potential French military counterweight just as the Plassey conspiracy was maturing
- B. It gave the Company its first access to Bengal's textile trade
- C. It marked the first Company factory established anywhere in Bengal
- D. It directly triggered the Black Hole incident

Answer: A. It removed Siraj-ud-Daulah's potential French military counterweight just as the Plassey conspiracy was maturing

Explanation: The other options are chronologically impossible: Company textile-trade access and its first Bengal factories long predated 1757, and the Black Hole (1756) preceded Chandernagore's capture (1757), not the reverse.

Q30. What is the most defensible reading of the Jagat Seth banking house's motive for joining the Plassey conspiracy?

- A. Religious solidarity with the incoming Company administration
- B. Protecting their credit and banking interests, which Siraj-ud-Daulah's hostility and unpredictability threatened
- C. A personal blood feud with Siraj-ud-Daulah's family stretching back generations
- D. Direct instructions from the Mughal emperor Alamgir II

Answer: B. Protecting their credit and banking interests, which Siraj-ud-Daulah's hostility and unpredictability threatened

Explanation: The Jagat Seths' documented concern was financial and institutional self-preservation under an unpredictable young Nawab, fitting the broader pattern of interest-based, not simply ideological, participation.

Q31. What official position did Rai Durlabh hold in Siraj-ud-Daulah's administration before joining the Plassey conspiracy?

- A. Mir Bakshi (paymaster-general)
- B. Naib Nazim of Bihar
- C. Diwan (chief revenue officer) of Bengal
- D. Qiladar of Munger fort

Answer: C. Diwan (chief revenue officer) of Bengal

Explanation: Rai Durlabh was Bengal's Diwan; Mir Jafar held the Mir Bakshi post, and the other two positions belong to different office-holders later in this topic's timeline.

Q32. What was Amichand (Omichand)'s specific role in the events preceding Plassey?

- A. Commander of Siraj-ud-Daulah's cavalry wing
- B. Bengal's Diwan and chief revenue officer
- C. The Mughal-appointed governor of Bihar
- D. A wealthy merchant-broker who demanded a commission for his conspiracy role and was deceived by Clive's forged 'red treaty'

Answer: D. A wealthy merchant-broker who demanded a commission for his conspiracy role and was deceived by Clive's forged 'red treaty'

Explanation: Amichand was a merchant-broker central to the conspiracy's financing and negotiation, not a military commander, revenue officer, or provincial governor.

Q33. Robert Clive's role at Plassey is best described in modern analysis as combining which two functions?

- A. Military commander and chief political negotiator of the conspiracy
- B. Naval admiral and chief revenue collector
- C. Mughal-appointed provincial governor and religious mediator
- D. Company director in London and Parliamentary representative

Answer: A. Military commander and chief political negotiator of the conspiracy

Explanation: Clive personally led both the nominal battlefield operation and the secret political negotiations with Mir Jafar's camp -- central to reading Plassey as a political coup rather than a purely military event.

Q34. Why should the traditionally cited Plassey casualty figures (around 29 Company dead, several hundred on Siraj's side) be treated cautiously in an answer?

- A. Because no casualties actually occurred; the figures are entirely fictional
- B. Because they are widely repeated textbook figures without confirmed modern forensic verification, and should be flagged as such
- C. Because the real casualty count was over ten thousand on each side
- D. Because the Company later officially retracted these figures in Parliament

Answer: B. Because they are widely repeated textbook figures without confirmed modern forensic verification, and should be flagged as such

Explanation: The figures are neither fictional nor formally retracted; the defensible position is to state them as conventional textbook figures with an explicit qualifying caveat, not as precisely audited certainties.

Q35. Which of the following was NOT part of the immediate 1757 Plassey settlement?

- A. Mir Jafar's installation as Nawab of Bengal
- B. Company compensation payments and territorial concessions
- C. The grant of Diwani rights over Bengal, Bihar and Orissa
- D. Confirmation of the Company's Calcutta trading privileges

Answer: C. The grant of Diwani rights over Bengal, Bihar and Orissa

Explanation: The Diwani grant came only in 1765 via the Treaty of Allahabad, eight years after Plassey; the other three were genuinely part of the 1757 settlement.

Q36. Approximately how much compensation did Mir Jafar pay the Company and its officials in the aftermath of Plassey, per the scholarly estimate this topic uses?

- A. Around 5 lakh rupees
- B. Around 50 lakh rupees
- C. Around 90 lakh rupees
- D. Around Rs 1.77 crore across compensation and gifts combined

Answer: D. Around Rs 1.77 crore across compensation and gifts combined

Explanation: This figure is carried as a scholarly estimate for combined compensation and gifts, not an exact treasury audit, and should not be confused with the later, much smaller Diwani tribute or Awadh indemnity figures.

Q37. What personal grant did Robert Clive receive from Mir Jafar in addition to Company compensation?

- A. A jagir (land grant) yielding a substantial personal annual income, on top of personal gifts
- B. The formal title of Nawab of Bengal
- C. Command of the Mughal imperial army
- D. Ownership of the Jagat Seth banking house

Answer: A. A jagir (land grant) yielding a substantial personal annual income, on top of personal gifts

Explanation: Clive's jagir grant became a major point of later controversy, including in his 1772-73 parliamentary scrutiny, precisely because it was a personal, not institutional, gain.

Q38. After Plassey, how did the Company primarily sustain its political leverage over Bengal's Nawab?

- A. Through direct Mughal imperial appointment as co-ruler
- B. Through its role as kingmaker and financier, with a Nawab dependent on continued Company military support against external threats
- C. Through a permanent occupation force stationed inside Murshidabad's palace
- D. Through control of the Nawab's personal religious establishment

Answer: B. Through its role as kingmaker and financier, with a Nawab dependent on continued Company military support against external threats

Explanation: The Company's leverage was structural and financial-military, best understood as the extraction 'circuit' described for the 1757-60 period, not imperial appointment, palace occupation, or religious control.

Q39. Why did the Company's demands on Mir Jafar escalate rather than stabilise after 1757?

- A. Mir Jafar voluntarily offered ever-larger gifts to secure Company favour
- B. The Mughal emperor demanded an increased tribute share from the Company
- C. The Company's own regional military and administrative costs kept rising, and it passed these costs on to a Nawab it now effectively controlled
- D. Bengal's agricultural output increased, allowing larger extractions without strain

Answer: C. The Company's own regional military and administrative costs kept rising, and it passed these costs on to a Nawab it now effectively controlled

Explanation: Rising Company costs, not voluntary generosity, imperial pressure, or an agricultural windfall, drove the escalating demands that eventually exhausted Mir Jafar's capacity to pay.

Q40. Which of the following was part of Mir Qasim's military and fiscal reform programme after 1760?

- A. Disbanding his standing army entirely in favour of feudal levies
- B. Outsourcing all revenue collection to European trading companies
- C. Adopting French artillery exclusively while banning Indian gunsmiths
- D. Reorganising and modernising his army's training and equipment while tightening fiscal administration from his new Munger base

Answer: D. Reorganising and modernising his army's training and equipment while tightening fiscal administration from his new Munger base

Explanation: Mir Qasim's programme aimed at strengthening, not disbanding, his military and administrative capacity; the other options describe measures he did not undertake.

Q41. The Patna Massacre of October 1763 refers to which event?

- A. The killing of a group of English Company prisoners on Mir Qasim's orders during his conflict with the Company
- B. A Company massacre of Bengali weavers protesting duty policy
- C. The killing of Siraj-ud-Daulah by Mir Jafar's son
- D. A famine-related mass-death event in Patna city

Answer: A. The killing of a group of English Company prisoners on Mir Qasim's orders during his conflict with the Company

Explanation: The Patna Massacre refers specifically to Mir Qasim's killing of English captives during the escalating 1763 conflict; the other options describe unrelated or fictional events.

Q42. In which order did Mir Qasim suffer defeats against the Company in 1763, before fleeing to Awadh?

- A. Udhanala, then Giria, then Katwa
- B. Katwa, then Giria, then Udhanala
- C. Giria, then Udhanala, then Katwa
- D. All three battles were fought simultaneously on a single day

Answer: B. Katwa, then Giria, then Udhanala

Explanation: The sequence of reverses at Katwa, Giria and Udhanala through 1763 progressively weakened Mir Qasim's position before his flight to Awadh; the other orderings do not match the actual campaign chronology.

Q43. After his 1763 defeats, where did Mir Qasim take refuge, setting up the coalition that fought at Buxar?

- A. The Maratha court at Pune
- B. The Mysore court under Haidar Ali
- C. Shuja-ud-Daula's court in Awadh
- D. The Sikh Misls in Punjab

Answer: C. Shuja-ud-Daula's court in Awadh

Explanation: Mir Qasim fled to Awadh, where Shuja-ud-Daula's protection and shared interest with the fugitive emperor Shah Alam II formed the coalition that met the Company at Buxar in 1764.

Q44. The Battle of Buxar was fought on which date, at a location on which river?

- A. 23 June 1757, on the Bhagirathi-Hooghly
- B. 12 August 1765, on the Ganges near Allahabad
- C. 2 January 1757, on the Hooghly at Calcutta
- D. 22 October 1764, on the Ganges near Buxar in present-day Bihar

Answer: D. 22 October 1764, on the Ganges near Buxar in present-day Bihar

Explanation: The other three dates/locations belong to Plassey, the Treaty of Allahabad, and the Fort William recapture respectively -- each a genuinely different event in this topic's chronology.

Q45. Major Hector Munro commanded the Company forces at Buxar; which of these best describes his command's key structural advantage?

- A. A single, unified chain of command, unlike the coalition's three separate treasuries and commanders
- B. Overwhelming numerical superiority of at least five to one
- C. Superior knowledge of the local terrain from decades of prior residence
- D. Direct reinforcement from a simultaneous naval bombardment

Answer: A. A single, unified chain of command, unlike the coalition's three separate treasuries and commanders

Explanation: Munro's force was actually outnumbered by the coalition; its decisive advantage was unified command and coordination, not numbers, terrain familiarity, or naval support -- Buxar was an inland battle with no naval role.

Q46. What happened to Mir Qasim after the Company's victory at Buxar?

- A. He was restored as Nawab of Bengal under a new treaty
- B. He disappeared into obscurity, dying in reduced circumstances some years later without recovering political power
- C. He was executed publicly by the Company at Munger
- D. He became the Company's first Naib Diwan

Answer: B. He disappeared into obscurity, dying in reduced circumstances some years later without recovering political power

Explanation: Unlike Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II, who both received negotiated 1765 settlements, Mir Qasim's political career effectively ended at Buxar without restoration, execution, or an administrative post.

Q47. What was Shah Alam II's status under the 1765 Treaty of Allahabad arrangements?

- A. Full sovereign ruler of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa with real administrative power
- B. Formally deposed and stripped of the imperial title altogether
- C. Nominal Mughal emperor, recognised in title, but a Company-supported pensioner holding Kora and Allahabad districts
- D. Appointed as the Company's Resident at Murshidabad

Answer: C. Nominal Mughal emperor, recognised in title, but a Company-supported pensioner holding Kora and Allahabad districts

Explanation: Shah Alam II retained his imperial title and received Kora, Allahabad, and an annual payment, but held no genuine administrative power over Bengal -- distinct from full sovereignty, deposition, or a Company post.

Q48. What annual tribute did the Company agree to pay the Mughal emperor in exchange for the Diwani grant of 1765?

- A. 50 lakh rupees
- B. 90 lakh rupees
- C. 1.77 crore rupees
- D. 26 lakh rupees

Answer: D. 26 lakh rupees

Explanation: The 26-lakh figure is the Diwani tribute to the emperor; the other figures belong to different transactions (Awadh's indemnity and post-Plassey compensation) and should not be substituted for one another.

Q49. Which two districts were ceded to Shah Alam II as part of the 1765 Allahabad settlement, forming the material basis of his pensioner status?

- A. Kora and Allahabad
- B. Munger and Patna
- C. Murshidabad and Kasimbazar
- D. Awadh and Lucknow

Answer: A. Kora and Allahabad

Explanation: Kora and Allahabad were the specific districts assigned to the emperor; the other pairs name places tied to different actors, including Awadh itself, which remained Shuja-ud-Daula's separately restored territory.

Q50. What indemnity did Shuja-ud-Daula pay the Company under the separate 1765 Awadh treaty?

- A. 26 lakh rupees
- B. 50 lakh rupees
- C. 1.77 crore rupees
- D. No indemnity was required; Awadh was restored unconditionally

Answer: B. 50 lakh rupees

Explanation: The 50-lakh indemnity was Shuja-ud-Daula's payment for the restoration of most of his territory; the 26-lakh figure belongs to the separate Diwani tribute, and the restoration was conditional, not unconditional.

Q51. What powers did the Diwani specifically confer on its holder?

- A. Command of the Nawab's standing army
- B. Criminal justice administration across Bengal
- C. The right to collect land revenue and administer civil justice in Bengal, Bihar and Orissa
- D. Appointment of the Mughal emperor's own household staff

Answer: C. The right to collect land revenue and administer civil justice in Bengal, Bihar and Orissa

Explanation: Revenue collection and civil justice were the Diwani's specific domain; military command and criminal justice belonged to the Nizamat, and household appointments were an unrelated Mughal court function.

Q52. Which powers remained, at least nominally, within the Nizamat rather than the Diwani after 1765?

- A. Land revenue collection across the three provinces
- B. Civil justice administration in revenue disputes
- C. The 26-lakh annual tribute payment to the emperor
- D. Criminal justice administration and nominal military command, formally retained by the Nawab's office

Answer: D. Criminal justice administration and nominal military command, formally retained by the Nawab's office

Explanation: These functions stayed with the Nizamat in form, even as Company-influenced deputies effectively ran much administration in practice; the other options describe Diwani-side functions or the separate tribute arrangement.

Q53. Who were appointed as the Company's principal Naib Diwans (deputy revenue administrators) for Bengal and Bihar respectively during the Dual Government?

- A. Muhammad Reza Khan for Bengal and Raja Shitab Rai for Bihar
- B. Mir Jafar for Bengal and Mir Qasim for Bihar
- C. Robert Clive for Bengal and Hector Munro for Bihar
- D. Warren Hastings for Bengal and Robert Clive for Bihar

Answer: A. Muhammad Reza Khan for Bengal and Raja Shitab Rai for Bihar

Explanation: Muhammad Reza Khan and Raja Shitab Rai were the actual Indian intermediaries administering revenue for the Company; the other names belong to earlier Nawabs or Company officials holding different roles.

Q54. In 1772, Warren Hastings ended the Dual Government by taking which specific step?

- A. Formally annexing Bengal to the British Crown
- B. Having the Company itself 'stand forth as Diwan,' assuming direct revenue administration rather than governing through Naib Diwans
- C. Restoring full sovereign power to the Nawab of Bengal
- D. Transferring the Diwani back to the Mughal emperor

Answer: B. Having the Company itself 'stand forth as Diwan,' assuming direct revenue administration rather than governing through Naib Diwans

Explanation: Hastings's own phrase, that the Company would 'stand forth as Diwan,' captures the shift to direct administration; Crown annexation came only in 1858, and no full Nawabi restoration or Diwani reversion occurred.

Q55. Which combination of factors is the most defensible explanation for the severity of the Bengal famine of 1770?

- A. Drought alone, with governance playing no meaningful role
- B. Company revenue policy alone, with no natural trigger
- C. A poor 1768 harvest and 1769-70 drought combined with revenue rigidity, commercial priorities and Dual Government administrative confusion
- D. A sudden, unprecedented locust infestation with no prior harvest problems

Answer: C. A poor 1768 harvest and 1769-70 drought combined with revenue rigidity, commercial priorities and Dual Government administrative confusion

Explanation: The sources consulted converge on compound causation combining natural and governance factors; monocausal claims and the unsupported locust claim overstate certainty the evidence does not provide.

Q56. Which sequence best captures the Company's transformation described in this topic, from trader to sovereign power?

- A. Sovereign power first, then trading company, then kingmaker
- B. Kingmaker first, then sovereign power, then trading company
- C. Trading company and sovereign power simultaneously from the Company's founding in 1600
- D. Trading company with local privileges, then political kingmaker after Plassey, then direct revenue sovereign after Buxar and the Diwani grant

Answer: D. Trading company with local privileges, then political kingmaker after Plassey, then direct revenue sovereign after Buxar and the Diwani grant

Explanation: This sequence -- commerce, then political leverage, then formal revenue sovereignty -- is the structural transformation this topic traces, unfolding across nearly a decade, not instantaneously or in reverse order.

Q57. Which of these best reflects a 'constrained choice' rather than a simple 'betrayal' reading of Mir Jafar's role in the Plassey conspiracy?

- A. Mir Jafar, as a senior military commander sidelined by Siraj-ud-Daulah's inner circle, saw an alliance with the Company as his best available path to power
- B. Mir Jafar acted purely out of personal greed with no institutional context whatsoever
- C. Mir Jafar was coerced at gunpoint into signing the conspiracy treaty
- D. Mir Jafar had no prior relationship with Siraj-ud-Daulah's court and joined the conspiracy as an outsider

Answer: A. Mir Jafar, as a senior military commander sidelined by Siraj-ud-Daulah's inner circle, saw an alliance with the Company as his best available path to power

Explanation: Reading his choice through his actual institutional position is the 'constrained choice' framing this topic uses, in contrast to a purely moralised, coercion-based, or context-free account.

Q58. Which named historian's phrase 'open plunder and loot,' cited within Bipan Chandra's own analysis, represents the nationalist historiographical critique of Company extraction from Bengal?

- A. Percival Spear
- B. R.C. Dutt
- C. P.J. Marshall
- D. C.A. Bayly

Answer: B. R.C. Dutt

Explanation: R.C. Dutt's characterisation, as cited in Bipan Chandra's work, represents the nationalist economic-drain critique; Marshall and Bayly represent a different, corporate/fiscal-military-state historiographical lens.

Q59. The 'collaboration thesis' historiographical lens on Plassey and its aftermath emphasises which analytical focus?

- A. Purely military tactics and troop-movement analysis
- B. A single moral verdict of collective Indian betrayal
- C. The specific institutional interests (bankers, nobles, military commanders) that led Indian elites to align with the Company at particular moments
- D. Denial that Bengal's political economy played any role in the conquest

Answer: C. The specific institutional interests (bankers, nobles, military commanders) that led Indian elites to align with the Company at particular moments

Explanation: This lens, associated with the wider Cambridge school approach, is precisely about specific, interest-based elite alignment, not troop movements, a single moral verdict, or a denial of political-economy context.

Q60. Which historiographical framing, associated with historians such as P.J. Marshall and C.A. Bayly, describes the Company's post-Plassey transformation?

- A. The 'betrayal narrative,' focused solely on Mir Jafar's personal culpability
- B. The 'pure commerce' view, denying any political or military dimension to the Company's activity
- C. The 'monocausal drought' explanation applied to the entire conquest period
- D. The 'corporate-military-fiscal state' framing, describing the Company's fusion of trading, taxing and war-making functions into a single institutional form

Answer: D. The 'corporate-military-fiscal state' framing, describing the Company's fusion of trading, taxing and war-making functions into a single institutional form

Explanation: This framing captures the Company's institutional fusion of commerce, coercion and revenue administration, distinct from a personalised betrayal narrative, a purely commercial view, or an unrelated drought-based explanation.

Q61. Which historiographical approach, associated with historians such as Sekhar Bandyopadhyay, situates the conquest within Bengal's own pre-existing political-economic structures rather than treating it as an external event imposed on a passive region?

- A. The Bengal political-economy approach, tracing continuities and ruptures in Bengal's own commercial and agrarian structures across the conquest period
- B. The 'sudden rupture' approach, treating 1757 as a total break with no prior continuity
- C. The 'purely religious' approach, framing the conquest as a primarily sectarian conflict
- D. The 'great man' approach, explaining the conquest solely through Clive's individual genius

Answer: A. The Bengal political-economy approach, tracing continuities and ruptures in Bengal's own commercial and agrarian structures across the conquest period

Explanation: This approach foregrounds Bengal's own internal political-economic structures and continuities, in contrast to a sudden-rupture, sectarian, or purely biographical framing.

Q62. In a comparative assessment, why is Buxar often judged strategically more decisive than Plassey, despite Plassey's greater fame?

- A. Buxar involved a larger territorial area than all of Bengal
- B. Buxar, through the subsequent Treaty of Allahabad, produced the Company's formal legal revenue title (the Diwani), whereas Plassey only changed Bengal's ruling personnel
- C. Buxar was fought entirely without any Indian participants on either side
- D. Plassey is historiographically disputed while Buxar's outcome faces no historical debate

Answer: B. Buxar, through the subsequent Treaty of Allahabad, produced the Company's formal legal revenue title (the Diwani), whereas Plassey only changed Bengal's ruling personnel

Explanation: The decisive distinction is legal-institutional, not territorial scale, participant composition, or relative historiographical controversy -- both battles in fact involve debate and predominantly Indian troops on most sides.

Q63. Topic 04 ends its narrative at 1772-73. Which subsequent development is explicitly handed to a later topic (Topic 06) rather than analysed in depth here?

- A. The Battle of Buxar's tactical details
- B. The exact terms of the 1765 Diwani grant
- C. The 1773 Regulating Act's reform of Company governance structures
- D. The 1763 abolition of internal transit duties by Mir Qasim

Answer: C. The 1773 Regulating Act's reform of Company governance structures

Explanation: The Regulating Act of 1773, and the constitutional reforms that followed it, are explicitly Topic 06's material; Topic 04's own boundary ends at the Dual Government's 1772 termination, used here only as a forward-looking bridge.

Q64. How many Prelims or Mains questions are directly routed to Topic 04 in this repository's own PYQ ledgers, as verified by this topic's audit?

- A. Twelve, spread evenly across the past decade
- B. Three, all from the 2013-2015 period
- C. One, from 2022, owned exclusively by this topic
- D. Zero directly routed items; only two adjacent items exist, both explicitly owned by other topics and used here strictly as bounded, labelled bridges

Answer: D. Zero directly routed items; only two adjacent items exist, both explicitly owned by other topics and used here strictly as bounded, labelled bridges

Explanation: The repository's own ledgers show zero PYQs routed to Topic 04; the two adjacent items used in this package are explicitly attributed to their owning topics (05 and 07), never claimed as Topic 04's own.

Remedial MCQs (16; targeted at this topic's most common specific errors)

Each item below corrects a real, frequently seen misstatement. Read the flawed student statement, then select the accurate remedial correction.

Six recurring UPSC traps on the conquest of Bengal

TRAPS

	Correct position
'Plassey was won primarily through superior British battlefield tactics and firepower'	It was decided chiefly by a pre-arranged political conspiracy; combat was limited to one small loyal wing
'The Black Hole of Calcutta is a precisely documented tragedy with a verified death toll'	It rests on a single contested source (Holwell); Indian nationalist opinion later challenged both its facts and its political use
'Mir Qasim's abolition of duties was primarily an anti-British nationalist act'	It aimed at equal, uniform taxation for all merchants, Indian and European alike, and only secondarily provoked Company hostility
'The Treaty of Allahabad handed the Company complete sovereign control of Bengal in 1765'	It granted the Diwani (revenue right); the Nizamat (police, justice, military) nominally stayed with the Nawab
'The 1770 famine was caused solely by drought and crop failure'	Both core textbook sources treat it as a compound failure of harvest, revenue rigidity and administrative confusion
'Dual Government means the Company and the Nawab shared power roughly equally'	The Company held real power without formal responsibility; the Nawab's government held nominal responsibility without real power

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Six traps that recur across Prelims options and Mains framing on this topic

Visual 25: Six recurring UPSC traps on the conquest of Bengal, matched to the remedial items below

Visual 25: Six recurring UPSC traps on the conquest of Bengal, matched to the remedial items below. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Q65. A student writes: 'The 1717 farman itself authorised Company servants to trade duty-free using dastaks for their personal goods.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. The farman authorised only the Company's own registered trade goods; dastak misuse for servants' personal trade was an unauthorised extension that Nawabs consistently resisted
- B. The statement is entirely accurate as written
- C. The farman authorised personal trade but only for goods worth under a fixed value
- D. The farman was issued in 1757, not 1717, making the entire statement's date wrong

Answer: A. The farman authorised only the Company's own registered trade goods; dastak misuse for servants' personal trade was an unauthorised extension that Nawabs consistently resisted

Explanation: This is the single most common conflation in this topic; the date 1717 is itself correct, so the fix is scope (Company-only vs personal), not the year.

Q66. A student writes: 'Plassey was a hard-fought, evenly matched pitched battle decided by superior British tactics.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. The statement is accurate; British tactical superiority alone explains the outcome
- B. Real fighting was confined mainly to Mir Madan's and Mohan Lal's small loyal wing; the bulk of Siraj's nominal force, under conspirators Mir Jafar and Rai Durlabh, never engaged -- making this substantially a political, not tactical, victory
- C. The battle lasted several days of continuous fighting before a British breakthrough
- D. Naval bombardment, not land tactics, decided the battle

Answer: B. Real fighting was confined mainly to Mir Madan's and Mohan Lal's small loyal wing; the bulk of Siraj's nominal force, under conspirators Mir Jafar and Rai Durlabh, never engaged -- making this substantially a political, not tactical, victory

Explanation: The evenly-matched/tactical-superiority framing, and the multi-day and naval-bombardment variants, all misdescribe Plassey's actual, largely pre-arranged, one-day outcome.

Q67. A student writes: 'The British conquest of Bengal was complete by 1757.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. The statement is accurate; nothing of significance happened after 1757
- B. The conquest was actually complete earlier, by 1740
- C. Plassey (1757) only changed Bengal's ruling personnel; the Company's durable legal revenue title came only with Buxar (1764) and the Treaty of Allahabad (1765) -- conquest in the fullest sense is an eight-year process, not a single 1757 event
- D. The conquest was not complete until the Regulating Act of 1773

Answer: C. Plassey (1757) only changed Bengal's ruling personnel; the Company's durable legal revenue title came only with Buxar (1764) and the Treaty of Allahabad (1765) -- conquest in the fullest sense is an eight-year process, not a single 1757 event

Explanation: While 1773 is too late a marker (governance reform, not conquest, is what that year addresses), the core correction is that 1757 alone did not establish revenue sovereignty -- that took until 1765.

Q68. A student writes: 'The Company received the Diwani of Bengal immediately after its victory at Plassey in 1757.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. The statement is accurate as written
- B. The Diwani was granted in 1740, well before Plassey
- C. The Diwani was granted at the Treaty of Alinagar in early 1757
- D. The Diwani was granted only in 1765, via the Treaty of Allahabad, eight years after Plassey, following the Company's separate victory at Buxar

Answer: D. The Diwani was granted only in 1765, via the Treaty of Allahabad, eight years after Plassey, following the Company's separate victory at Buxar

Explanation: This 1757-vs-1765 date confusion is one of the most heavily exam-tested traps in this topic; the eight-year gap and Buxar's intervening role must be stated explicitly.

Q69. A student writes: 'Mir Jafar granted the Company the Diwani of Bengal after Plassey in 1757.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. Mir Jafar granted the Company the zamindari of the 24 Parganas in 1757; the Diwani came only in 1765 from Emperor Shah Alam II, not from Mir Jafar
- B. The statement is accurate; Mir Jafar did grant the Diwani in 1757
- C. Mir Jafar granted the Nizamat, not the Diwani, in 1757
- D. No grant of any kind was made in 1757

Answer: A. Mir Jafar granted the Company the zamindari of the 24 Parganas in 1757; the Diwani came only in 1765 from Emperor Shah Alam II, not from Mir Jafar

Explanation: The specific 1757 grant was the 24-Parganas zamindari from Mir Jafar; the Diwani is a distinct 1765 grant from a different authority (the Mughal emperor), not the Nawab.

Q70. A student writes: 'Mir Jafar abolished internal transit duties to promote equal trade in 1763.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. The statement is accurate as written
- B. This measure belongs to Mir Qasim, not Mir Jafar; Mir Jafar had already been deposed in 1760, three years before this 1763 reform
- C. The measure was actually undertaken jointly by both Nawabs in sequence
- D. The measure refers to a Company policy, not any Nawab's initiative

Answer: B. This measure belongs to Mir Qasim, not Mir Jafar; Mir Jafar had already been deposed in 1760, three years before this 1763 reform

Explanation: This is a common actor-confusion error; keeping the 1757-60 Mir Jafar period and the 1760-63 Mir Qasim period chronologically separate resolves it immediately.

Q71. A student writes: 'Alivardi Khan was defeated at the Battle of Giria.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. The statement is accurate as written
- B. There is no such place as Giria in this topic's chronology
- C. Alivardi Khan won at Giria in 1740 (over Sarfaraz Khan, to become Nawab); Mir Qasim suffered a defeat at a place also called Giria in 1763, during his conflict with the Company -- two different battles, 23 years apart
- D. Both Giria battles were fought against the Company by the same ruler

Answer: C. Alivardi Khan won at Giria in 1740 (over Sarfaraz Khan, to become Nawab); Mir Qasim suffered a defeat at a place also called Giria in 1763, during his conflict with the Company -- two different battles, 23 years apart

Explanation: The place-name repetition (Giria, 1740 and 1763) is a frequent trap; year-anchoring each battle to its correct ruler and opponent resolves the confusion.

Q72. A student writes: 'Mir Jafar and Jagat Seth led the coalition defeated at Buxar in 1764.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. The statement is accurate as written
- B. Mir Jafar and Jagat Seth were present at Buxar but played a minor role
- C. Only Jagat Seth was present at Buxar; Mir Jafar was not involved in this period at all
- D. Mir Jafar and Jagat Seth were 1757 Plassey conspirators; the 1764 Buxar coalition instead comprised Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II

Answer: D. Mir Jafar and Jagat Seth were 1757 Plassey conspirators; the 1764 Buxar coalition instead comprised Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II

Explanation: This is a common cross-event actor confusion; Plassey's conspirators (1757) and Buxar's coalition members (1764) are two entirely distinct sets of historical actors, separated by seven years and opposing loyalties.

Q73. A student writes: 'The Nizamat gave the Company the right to collect land revenue in Bengal.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. Revenue collection was the Diwani's function, held substantively by the Company; the Nizamat covered criminal justice and nominal military command, retained in form by the Nawab
- B. The statement is accurate as written
- C. Both the Diwani and Nizamat covered identical, overlapping functions with no real distinction
- D. The Nizamat was abolished in 1765, so it held no functions at all

Answer: A. Revenue collection was the Diwani's function, held substantively by the Company; the Nizamat covered criminal justice and nominal military command, retained in form by the Nawab

Explanation: This function-swap, attributing revenue collection to the Nizamat instead of the Diwani, is a frequent and serious factual error; the two offices had genuinely distinct domains.

Q74. A student writes: 'The Dual Government of 1765-72 meant Bengal was ruled jointly and equally by two separate Nawabs.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. The statement is accurate as written
- B. The Dual Government was not a two-Nawab arrangement at all; it was the Company, holding the substantive Diwani, governing alongside a single Nawab's nominal Nizamat, with real power concentrated in the Company's Naib Diwans
- C. It refers to joint rule by the Mughal emperor and the Nawab, with no Company role at all
- D. It refers to two separate Company Governors ruling different halves of Bengal

Answer: B. The Dual Government was not a two-Nawab arrangement at all; it was the Company, holding the substantive Diwani, governing alongside a single Nawab's nominal Nizamat, with real power concentrated in the Company's Naib Diwans

Explanation: 'Dual' refers to the Diwani-Nizamat split between the Company and one Nawab's office, not to two rival Nawabs or two Company governors -- a frequent terminological misreading.

Q75. A student writes: 'In 1772, Warren Hastings formally annexed Bengal to the British Crown, ending Mughal sovereignty.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. The statement is accurate as written
- B. Hastings restored full Mughal sovereignty over Bengal in 1772, reversing the Company's role entirely
- C. In 1772, Hastings ended the Dual Government by having the Company itself 'stand forth as Diwan' and administer revenue directly -- an internal administrative shift, not a Crown annexation, which occurred only in 1858
- D. Hastings's 1772 action concerned only Awadh, not Bengal

Answer: C. In 1772, Hastings ended the Dual Government by having the Company itself 'stand forth as Diwan' and administer revenue directly -- an internal administrative shift, not a Crown annexation, which occurred only in 1858

Explanation: This overclaim, confusing an internal Company administrative reform with formal Crown annexation (which came 86 years later, after the 1857 revolt), is a serious chronological error worth correcting precisely.

Q76. A student writes: 'The Bengal famine of 1770 was caused entirely by the East India Company's revenue extraction, with no role for natural conditions.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. The statement is accurate as written
- B. The famine was caused entirely by drought, with no Company policy role whatsoever
- C. The famine's precise mortality is a settled, census-verified fact requiring no further qualification
- D. The best-supported reading combines a poor 1768 harvest and 1769-70 drought with revenue rigidity, commercial priorities and Dual Government administrative confusion -- a compound cause, not a monocausal Company-only or drought-only explanation

Answer: D. The best-supported reading combines a poor 1768 harvest and 1769-70 drought with revenue rigidity, commercial priorities and Dual Government administrative confusion -- a compound cause, not a monocausal Company-only or drought-only explanation

Explanation: Monocausal claims in either direction overstate what the evidence supports; compound causation, stated explicitly, is the defensible position, and mortality figures should always carry an estimate/non-census caveat.

Q77. A student writes: 'The Treaty of Allahabad, 1765, was a single document granting the Diwani and restoring Awadh in one combined agreement.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. Two separate instruments were signed on the same day, 12 August 1765 -- one with Shah Alam II granting the Diwani, another with Shuja-ud-Daula restoring most of Awadh for an indemnity; treating them as one document elides a distinction examiners test directly
- B. The statement is accurate as written
- C. Only the Awadh treaty was signed in 1765; the Diwani grant came a decade later
- D. Only the Diwani treaty was signed in 1765; Awadh was never restored to Shuja-ud-Daula

Answer: A. Two separate instruments were signed on the same day, 12 August 1765 -- one with Shah Alam II granting the Diwani, another with Shuja-ud-Daula restoring most of Awadh for an indemnity; treating them as one document elides a distinction examiners test directly

Explanation: The 'two treaties, same day, different jobs' framing is essential; both events did occur in 1765, so the alternative date claims are also incorrect.

Q78. A student writes: 'The Black Hole of Calcutta is a settled historical fact with an exact, universally agreed death toll.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. The statement is accurate as written
- B. The episode rests substantially on a single interested narrator (Holwell) with no independent corroboration of the casualty count, and its memory has been historically contested, including the 1940 removal of its commemorative monument amid nationalist campaigning -- it should be discussed with explicit source-criticism, not treated as an exact settled fact
- C. The episode has been entirely disproven and definitely did not occur in any form
- D. The exact death toll was confirmed by twentieth-century forensic examination of Fort William's ruins

Answer: B. The episode rests substantially on a single interested narrator (Holwell) with no independent corroboration of the casualty count, and its memory has been historically contested, including the 1940 removal of its commemorative monument amid nationalist campaigning -- it should be discussed with explicit source-criticism, not treated as an exact settled fact

Explanation: The defensible position is neither blank certainty nor blank denial, but disciplined source-criticism -- acknowledging the episode is alleged and disputed in its specifics, without asserting it never happened at all.

Q79. A student writes: 'Exactly 500 of Siraj-ud-Daulah's soldiers and 29 Company soldiers died at Plassey, as confirmed by contemporary official casualty rolls.' What is the correct remedial statement?

- A. The statement is accurate as written, with official rolls confirming these exact numbers
- B. No casualties of any kind occurred at Plassey
- C. These are widely repeated traditional textbook figures, not numbers confirmed by any surviving official casualty roll; they should be presented with an explicit 'traditionally cited' qualifier rather than as audited certainties
- D. The real casualty figures were in the tens of thousands on each side

Answer: C. These are widely repeated traditional textbook figures, not numbers confirmed by any surviving official casualty roll; they should be presented with an explicit 'traditionally cited' qualifier rather than as audited certainties

Explanation: Precision-without-source is the trap here; adding a qualifying phrase before any casualty figure in this topic protects against exactly this kind of overreach.

Q80. A student writes: 'The 2022 GS-I Mains question on Company armies acquiring political power is a directly routed Topic 04 PYQ.' What is the correct remedial statement?

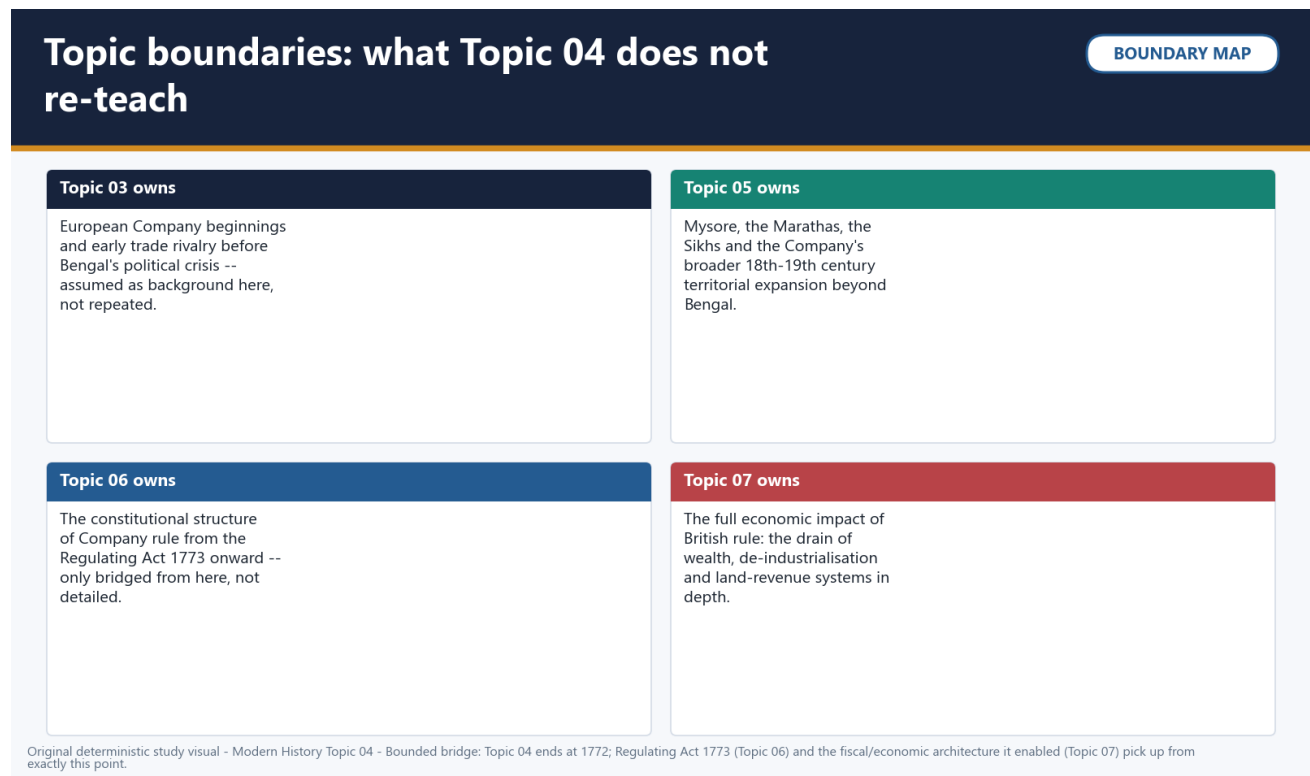
- A. The statement is accurate; this question is directly routed to Topic 04
- B. No such question exists in any repository ledger
- C. The question exists but is routed to Topic 06, not Topic 04
- D. This question is verified and used in this package, but it is explicitly owned by Topic 05 (broader territorial expansion) in the repository's ledgers and is used here only as a labelled, bounded adjacent bridge -- Topic 04 itself has zero directly routed PYQs

Answer: D. This question is verified and used in this package, but it is explicitly owned by Topic 05 (broader territorial expansion) in the repository's ledgers and is used here only as a labelled, bounded adjacent bridge -- Topic 04 itself has zero directly routed PYQs

Explanation: Overclaiming PYQ ownership violates this package's strict integrity policy; adjacent items must always carry their true owning topic, never be silently absorbed as if directly routed to the topic using them.

Mains practice: solved model answers

Word limits scale with marks in this package's own convention: 10 marks = 150 words, 15 marks = 250 words, 20 marks = 300 words. The "Directive alignment" and "Why this earns marks" notes are examiner-craft scaffolding around the answer, not part of the counted word limit.



Visual 21: Repeat: topic boundaries, previewed before Mains practice (see Mains 2's bounded bridge answer)

Visual 21: Repeat: topic boundaries, previewed before Mains practice (see Mains 2's bounded bridge answer).
Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Mains 1 - 10 marks | 150 words

Question: Examine the political method by which the English East India Company acquired the Diwani of Bengal in 1765.

Directive alignment: "Examine" requires identifying the actual mechanism -- military leverage converted into a legal instrument -- not a narrative retelling of battles.

Introduction: The Diwani was not won on a battlefield; it was negotiated from a position of military dominance established at Buxar.

Answer: The Diwani of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa was acquired through a two-step political method: military victory creating leverage, then a negotiated legal grant from the one authority still recognised as its source. Company forces under Hector Munro had defeated the Mir Qasim-Shuja-ud-Daula-Shah Alam II coalition at Buxar in October 1764. Rather than annex territory outright, Clive negotiated the Treaty of Allahabad (12 August 1765): Shah Alam II, a fugitive emperor without a throne, granted the Diwani in exchange for an annual tribute of 26 lakh rupees and two ceded districts, Kora and Allahabad, that gave him a nominal seat. This was conquest legitimised through Mughal legal form rather than open usurpation.

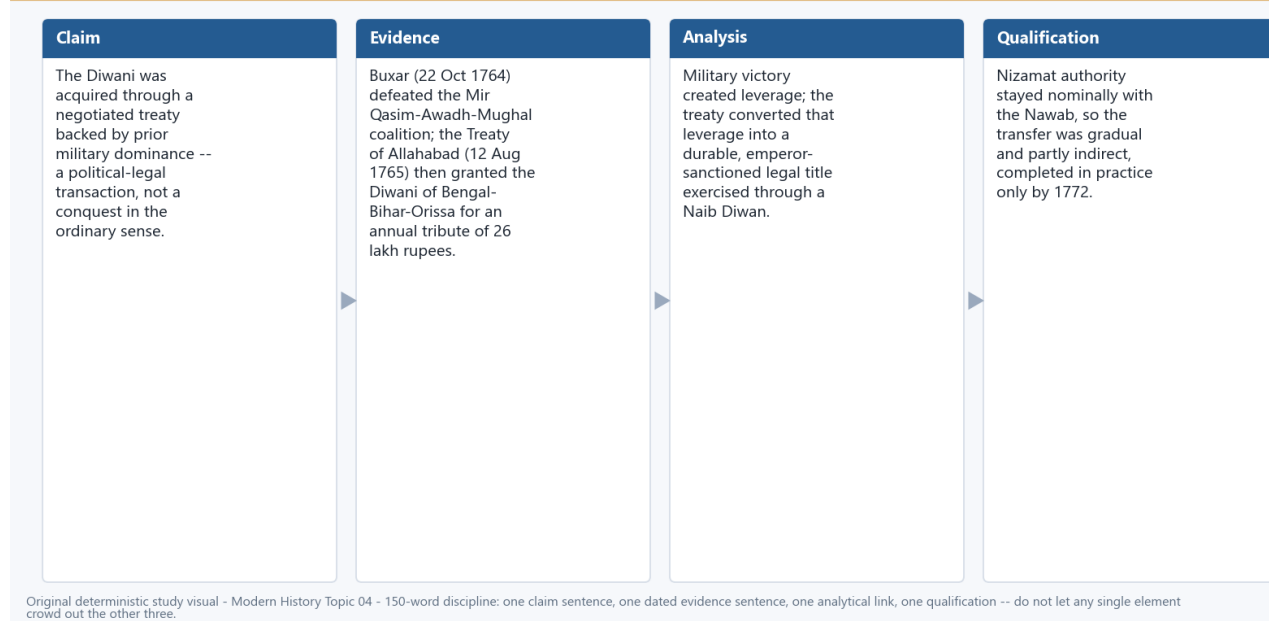
Qualification: The Nizamat (criminal justice, nominal military command) was not transferred in 1765; it stayed, in form, with the Nawab.

Verdict: The Company's method was to convert battlefield leverage into a legally sanctioned fiscal title, not to rule as an open conqueror.

Why this earns marks: Full marks require naming Buxar as the precondition, the exact 1765 instrument and authority (Shah Alam II, not Mir Jafar), the tribute figure, and the Nizamat's separate, unresolved status.

Answer spine, 10 marks: how the Company acquired the Diwani

ANSWER SPINE



Visual 22: Answer spine, 10 marks: the political method behind the 1765 Diwani grant

Visual 22: Answer spine, 10 marks: the political method behind the 1765 Diwani grant. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Mains 2 - 10 marks | 150 words (bounded bridge to a verified Topic 05 PYQ)

Question (2022 Mains GS-I, Q2 -- verified verbatim, owned by Modern History Topic 05): "Why did the armies of the British East India Company -- mostly comprising of Indian soldiers -- win consistently against the more numerous and better equipped armies of the then Indian rulers? Give reasons."

Boundary note: This question's complete answer (Mysore, Maratha and Sikh theatres, subsidiary-alliance financing, subcontinent-wide comparison) belongs to Topic 05. What follows is a bounded, explicitly labelled bridge answer drawing only on Topic 04's own Bengal evidence -- a partial illustration, not a complete answer to the full examination demand.

Directive alignment: "Why... Give reasons" calls for causal reasons, not a chronological account.

Introduction: Within Bengal alone, the Company's decisive victories at Plassey and Buxar rested less on raw military superiority and more on unified command exploiting the opposing camp's political divisions.

Answer (bounded to Topic 04 evidence only): At Plassey, Mir Jafar's and Rai Durlabh's wings, the bulk of Siraj-ud-Daulah's nominal strength, withheld their forces under a prior conspiracy; only Mir Madan's and Mohan Lal's small wing fought. At Buxar, the Mir Qasim-Shuja-ud-Daula-Shah Alam II coalition fielded a larger combined force but divided it across three separate treasuries and commanders, while Hector Munro commanded a single coordinated force. In both cases, Company success depended on converting an opponent's structural or political disunity into a battlefield advantage.

Qualification: This bridge covers only the Bengal theatre; the fuller comparative answer -- Mysore's centralised resistance, Maratha confederate rivalry, Sikh frontier collapse, and Company financing through Bengal's own revenues -- is Topic 05's material and is not attempted here.

Verdict: Bengal's evidence supports "disunity exploited by unified command" as one genuine causal thread, but this alone under-answers a subcontinent-wide question.

Why this earns marks: A candidate must recognise that a single-region answer, however well evidenced, under-answers a "then Indian rulers" (plural) question -- exactly the boundary discipline this package models by refusing to over-extend Topic 04's material into Topic 05's territory.

Mains 3 - 10 marks | 150 words

Question: Account for the source-critical problems in accepting the traditional narrative of the 1756 "Black Hole of Calcutta" as settled historical fact.

Directive alignment: "Account for" requires reasoned explanation of why the evidentiary basis is weak, not a retelling of the alleged events.

Introduction: The Black Hole episode is a case study in single-source history: its evidentiary weight rests almost entirely on one interested witness.

Answer: The narrative's central problem is that it derives almost wholly from John Zephaniah Holwell, a Company official and self-described survivor with a direct personal and institutional stake in dramatising Fort William's fall. No independent Indian, French, or neutral European account from 1756 corroborates Holwell's specific casualty figures, and subsequent scholarship has repeatedly noted the absence of any corroborating administrative or eyewitness record. The episode's contested memory is itself documented: colonial Calcutta's Holwell monument was removed from its central site in 1940 amid nationalist campaigning that questioned the narrative's political use. A single interested narrator, absent corroboration, and a demonstrably contested public memory together mean the episode should be presented as alleged and disputed, not audited fact.

Qualification: This does not require asserting the episode never happened in any form; the defensible position is agnosticism about scale and precision, not blanket denial.

Verdict: The Black Hole belongs in this topic as a case study in source criticism, not as a settled casualty count.

Why this earns marks: Full marks require naming Holwell specifically, stating the corroboration problem precisely, and citing the monument's contested memory as evidence of disputed status.

Mains 4 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Discuss why the Dual Government established by Robert Clive in Bengal (1765-72) failed as a system of governance, despite its apparent administrative convenience for the Company.

Directive alignment: "Discuss" requires weighing multiple structural causes, not a single-factor explanation.

Introduction: The Dual Government's failure was not incidental maladministration; it was a structural consequence of splitting power from responsibility between two authorities.

Structural design: Clive's 1765 arrangement gave the Company the substantively powerful Diwani (revenue collection, civil justice) through its own Naib Diwans, Muhammad Reza Khan in Bengal and Raja Shitab Rai in Bihar, while the Nawab retained only the nominal Nizamat (criminal justice, titular military command).

The accountability paradox: This created power without responsibility -- the Company, which controlled revenue, bore no formal administrative duty to Bengal's population -- and responsibility without power -- the Nawab's office, formally answerable for governance, controlled neither revenue nor real administrative machinery. Clive's own later testimony, in 1772, described the result as one where "corruption universally prevails, and confusion and mismanagement pervade every department."

Fiscal and administrative outcomes: Revenue collection prioritised short-term extraction over investment in agrarian or famine infrastructure, and the two-tier administrative chain (Company oversight, Naib Diwan implementation, local revenue officials beneath that) diffused responsibility so thoroughly that no single office could be held accountable for failures -- a vulnerability starkly exposed by the 1770 famine.

Qualification: The individual competence of the Naib Diwans is not primarily at issue; the failure is best read as designed into the structure itself, not attributable mainly to individual misconduct.

Verdict: The Dual Government failed because it deliberately separated power from responsibility on both sides of the arrangement -- precisely why Warren Hastings ended it in 1772 by having the Company itself "stand forth as Diwan."

Why this earns marks: A strong answer states both halves of the paradox explicitly, uses Clive's own 1772 testimony as evidence, and connects the structural failure forward to Hastings's remedy; naming only one half of the paradox caps the answer below full marks.

Answer spine, 15 marks: why the Dual Government failed

ANSWER SPINE

Claim	Evidence	Analysis	Qualification
The Dual Government failed because it split revenue power from administrative responsibility, producing accountability without any single accountable authority.	The Company held the Diwani but no formal governing duty; the Nawab's Nizamat retained nominal responsibility but no revenue or military resources; Clive told Parliament in 1772 that 'corruption universally prevails, and confusion and mismanagement pervade every department.'	Naib Diwans such as Muhammad Reza Khan answered to both a distant Company and a resourceless Nawab, so no one was positioned to correct fiscal or administrative failure -- a weakness the 1770 famine exposed starkly.	This was not simple incompetence; the design let the Company extract revenue while avoiding the political cost of direct rule -- Warren Hastings ended it only in 1772.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - 250-word discipline: give the split-authority claim first, then the paired evidence, then the causal analysis, then the qualification that this was designed, not accidental.

Visual 23: Answer spine, 15 marks: why the Dual Government failed structurally

Visual 23: Answer spine, 15 marks: why the Dual Government failed structurally. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Mains 5 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Evaluate Mir Qasim's administrative and fiscal reforms as Nawab of Bengal (1760-63), and explain why they brought him into direct conflict with the East India Company.

Directive alignment: "Evaluate... and explain" requires both an assessment of the reforms' substance and a causal account of the resulting conflict.

Introduction: Mir Qasim's short reign is best read as a genuine, if ultimately unsuccessful, attempt to rebuild Nawabi authority against mounting Company pressure.

Reform substance: After his 1760 installation, replacing the fiscally exhausted Mir Jafar, Mir Qasim shifted his capital from Murshidabad to Munger, gaining distance from Calcutta's influence while positioning himself nearer his own recruitment base; he reorganised and modernised his army's training and equipment, and tightened fiscal administration.

The equality measure: His most consequential step was the 1763 abolition of internal transit duties, applied equally to Indian and European traders alike, removing the tax advantage Company servants had exploited (often via dastak misuse) over Indian merchants.

Company response and conflict: Company traders, having lost their competitive advantage, protested; escalating friction produced open conflict, including the October 1763 Patna Massacre (the killing of English captives during hostilities) and a sequence of defeats for Mir Qasim at Katwa, Giria and Uddanala through 1763.

Aftermath: Defeated, Mir Qasim fled to Shuja-ud-Daula's Awadh, where the coalition that fought at Buxar in 1764 took shape.

Qualification: Mir Qasim's aims are better read as strengthening Nawabi sovereignty and ensuring commercial parity than as a modern anti-colonial nationalism; his conflict with the Company followed from lost privilege, not an anachronistic anti-imperial programme.

Verdict: Mir Qasim's reforms were substantively serious state-building measures whose direct effect -- removing Company servants' fiscal advantage -- made conflict with the Company almost unavoidable.

Why this earns marks: A complete answer names the specific reforms, the precise equality rationale, the Patna Massacre and defeat sequence, and correctly distinguishes Mir Qasim's aims from a retrospective nationalist framing.

Mains 6 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Examine the causes of the Bengal famine of 1770, and assess the extent to which the East India Company's administrative and revenue policies contributed to its severity.

Directive alignment: "Examine... and assess the extent" requires both cause-listing and a calibrated judgement of relative weight, not a monocausal verdict either way.

Introduction: The famine of 1770 is best explained as a natural trigger meeting a governance system unusually poorly positioned to absorb it.

Natural trigger: A poor 1768 harvest was compounded by drought conditions through 1769-70, reducing the food-grain base going into the crisis.

Governance vulnerability: This natural shock met a Dual Government marked by revenue rigidity (land revenue demands were not meaningfully relaxed to match falling output), commercial priorities that could crowd out subsistence considerations, and the administrative confusion built into the divided Diwani-Nizamat structure.

Weighing the contribution: The available evidence supports treating the Company's governance failures as a severity-amplifying factor operating alongside, not instead of, the natural trigger -- drought and harvest failure were real and would have caused hardship under any administration, but the Dual Government's specific rigidities plausibly worsened the outcome.

Qualification: Any specific mortality estimate (commonly cited loosely as "roughly one-third" of the affected population in some secondary accounts) should be treated as a repeated historiographical estimate, not a census-verified figure, and precise numbers should not be asserted as settled fact.

Verdict: The famine's severity is best explained by compound causation -- natural failure meeting institutional vulnerability -- with the Company's revenue rigidity as a real but not sole contributing factor.

Why this earns marks: Strong answers state both causal strands explicitly, calibrate the Company's contribution as amplifying rather than sole, and add an explicit mortality-estimate caveat.

Mains 7 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: "The British conquest of Bengal was as much the work of Indian bankers, nobles and soldiers as of the East India Company." Examine this statement with reference to the events of 1756-65.

Directive alignment: "Examine... with reference to" requires specific named evidence across the stated period, not generalised assertion.

Introduction: Read across 1756-65, Bengal's conquest depended at every decisive juncture on Indian actors making specific, interest-driven choices, not solely on Company initiative.

Financial and political actors: The Jagat Seth banking house's participation in the Plassey conspiracy protected its credit and banking interests against an unpredictable young Nawab; Mir Jafar, a senior commander sidelined within Siraj-ud-Daulah's court, saw alliance with the Company as his most viable path to power; Rai Durlabh, Bengal's Diwan, and the broker Amichand each pursued their own institutional or financial stakes.

Post-conquest administration: After 1765, the Dual Government depended entirely on Indian intermediaries -- Muhammad Reza Khan and Raja Shitab Rai as Naib Diwans -- without whom the Company had neither the administrative language nor local knowledge to collect revenue at all.

Resistance as counter-evidence: The statement is not one-directional collaboration only -- Mir Qasim's 1760-63 reforms and Siraj-ud-Daulah's own initial resistance to Company privilege show Indian agency running in both directions, resistance and alignment alike, each rooted in specific institutional calculation.

Qualification: This reading should not collapse into either a "willing collaboration" or a "simple betrayal" morality tale; each actor's choice reflected a real, bounded set of options, not free political agency in the modern sense, nor pure treachery.

Verdict: The statement is substantially correct: the conquest was co-produced by Company military-political method and specific, self-interested Indian financial, administrative and military participation.

Why this earns marks: A complete answer names specific individuals and their specific institutional motives, shows agency running in both directions, and explicitly avoids a single moralised verdict.

Mains 8 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Compare the nationalist and the "corporate-military-fiscal state" interpretations of the East India Company's transformation in Bengal after Plassey.

Directive alignment: "Compare" requires setting the two named lenses side by side on shared ground, not describing them in isolation.

Introduction: These two lenses read the same 1757-72 evidence toward different analytical ends -- moral-economic critique versus institutional description.

Nationalist lens: Associated with R.C. Dutt (whose characterisation of Company extraction as "open plunder and loot" is cited within Bipan Chandra's own analysis) and carried forward by Bipan Chandra's economic-nationalist historiography, this lens foregrounds the drain of wealth, the post-Plassey extraction circuit, and reads the Company's transformation primarily as organised economic exploitation with a clear moral verdict attached.

Corporate-military-fiscal state lens: Associated with historians such as P.J. Marshall and C.A. Bayly, this lens describes the same transformation institutionally -- the Company's fusion of trading, taxing and war-making functions into a single organisational form -- with less emphasis on moral verdict and more on explaining how such a fusion was administratively and fiscally possible.

Point of comparison: Both lenses agree on the empirical sequence (trader to kingmaker to revenue sovereign) and both take the extraction evidence seriously; they differ chiefly in whether the analytical centre of gravity is moral-economic critique or institutional-structural description.

Qualification: These are not the only two lenses available -- collaboration-thesis and Bengal-political-economy approaches (the latter associated with Sekhar Bandyopadhyay) offer further angles this comparison does not exhaust.

Verdict: The two lenses are complementary rather than contradictory: one supplies moral-economic judgement, the other institutional mechanism.

Why this earns marks: Full marks require naming specific historians correctly attributed to each lens, identifying genuine points of both agreement and difference, and avoiding the error of treating one lens as simply "right" and the other "wrong."

Mains 9 - 20 marks | 300 words

Question: "Plassey supplied the political opening, but Buxar and the Treaty of Allahabad supplied the durable institutional foundation of British power in Bengal." Critically examine this statement.

Directive alignment: "Critically examine" requires testing the statement's claim against evidence for and against, not simply illustrating it.

Introduction: This statement's core distinction -- regime change versus legal-institutional foundation -- holds up well against the evidence, though it requires qualification about intervening developments.

The case for the statement: Plassey (23 June 1757) replaced Siraj-ud-Daulah with the Company's chosen client Mir Jafar, but changed nothing in Bengal's formal constitutional position -- the Company remained, in law, a chartered trading concern operating under Mughal-derived local privilege. Only Buxar (22 October 1764), where a unified Company command under Hector Munro defeated the combined Mir Qasim-Shuja-ud-Daula-Shah Alam II coalition, and the subsequent Treaty of Allahabad (12 August 1765) -- granting the Diwani of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa from the emperor himself in exchange for a 26-lakh tribute -- gave the Company a durable, legally sourced revenue title.

Testing the claim against intervening developments: Between 1757 and 1764, the post-Plassey extraction circuit and Mir Jafar's 1760 deposition show the Company was already exercising substantial de facto political control well before Buxar, so "political opening" understates how much power Plassey's aftermath actually generated, even without a legal title attached.

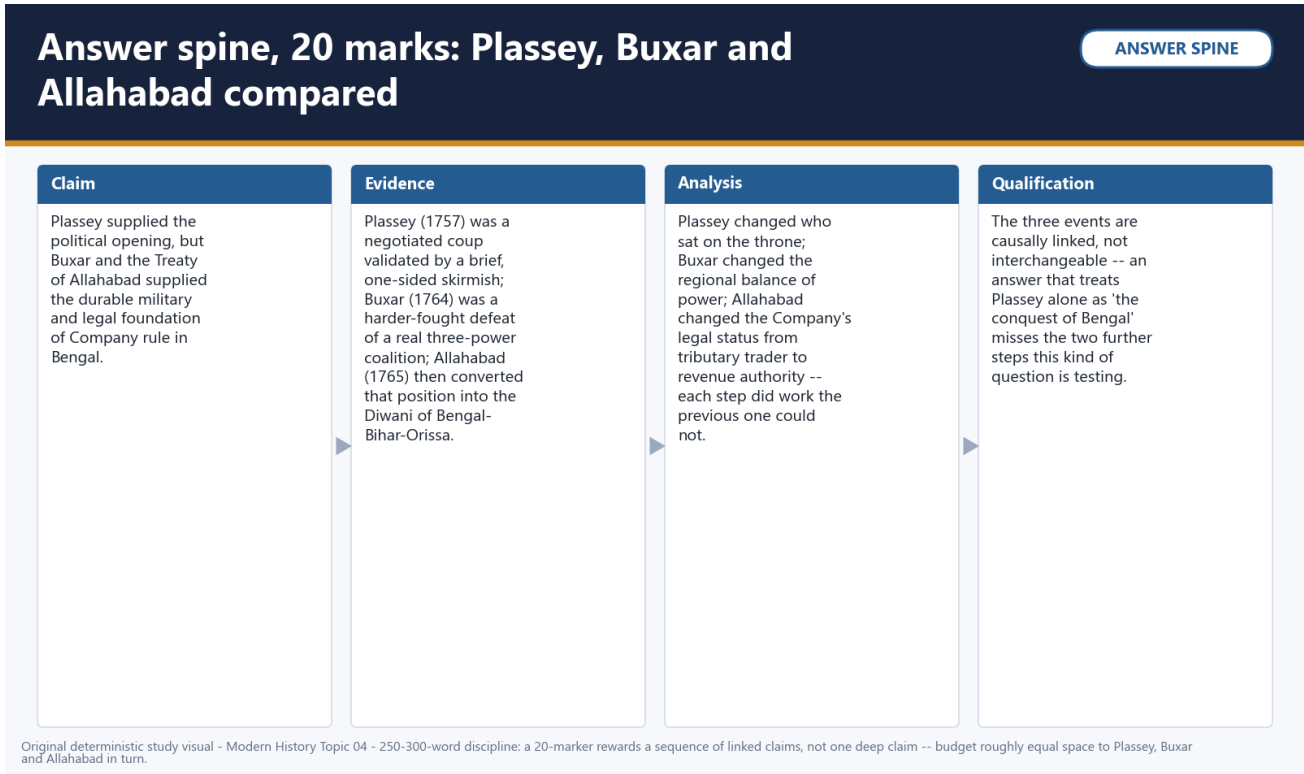
Assessing durability: Still, 1757-64's power remained personalist and revocable, dependent on which client Nawab the Company could install or depose, whereas the Diwani was a title good against successive Nawabs and against later Parliamentary scrutiny -- an institutional fact rather than a personal arrangement.

The Nizamat qualification: Even after 1765, the Nizamat remained formally with the Nawab, so "durable institutional foundation" should be read as revenue and administrative dominance specifically, not total, unqualified sovereignty.

Qualification: The statement's binary slightly understates the substantial de facto power the Company already held in 1757-64; the more precise formulation is that Plassey opened informal political dominance, and Buxar-Allahabad converted it into formal, legal sovereignty.

Verdict: The statement is broadly correct, provided "political opening" is not read as merely nominal.

Why this earns marks: A top answer engages critically rather than restating the quotation, and precisely distinguishes Diwani-level durability from the still-nominal Nizamat.



Visual 24: Answer spine, 20 marks: Plassey's opening versus Buxar-Allahabad's institutional foundation

Visual 24: Answer spine, 20 marks: Plassey's opening versus Buxar-Allahabad's institutional foundation. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Mains 10 - 20 marks | 300 words

Question: Trace the transformation of the English East India Company from a chartered trading concern to a territorial revenue-collecting power in Bengal between 1757 and 1772, and examine the main drivers of this transformation at each stage.

Directive alignment: "Trace... and examine the main drivers" requires a staged chronological account paired with causal analysis at each stage.

Introduction: The Company's transformation unfolded in three distinguishable stages, each driven by a different mechanism: political kingmaking, coalition victory, and legal-institutional conversion.

Stage one -- political kingmaker (1757-60): Following Plassey, the driver was leverage over a dependent client Nawab: Mir Jafar's payments, Clive's personal jagir, and the Company's escalating fiscal demands, tied to its own rising regional military costs, produced a self-reinforcing extraction circuit Mir Jafar could not indefinitely sustain, ending in his 1760 deposition.

Stage two -- contested sovereignty (1760-64): Mir Qasim's attempt to rebuild genuine Nawabi authority directly threatened Company commercial privilege, driving escalating conflict that culminated in his defeat and flight to Awadh, and the formation of the Buxar coalition.

Stage three -- legal-institutional conversion (1764-72): The driver shifted from political manoeuvre to formal institution-building: Buxar's unified-command victory, followed by the Diwani grant, converted military dominance into a legally sourced revenue title; the Dual Government then attempted, and structurally failed, to administer this title

through Indian intermediaries under a nominal Nawab, prompting Hastings's 1772 decision to have the Company itself "stand forth as Diwan."

Cross-stage continuity: Across all three stages, the recurring driver is the Company's growing need to fund its own expanding military-political commitments, requiring progressively more secure and direct access to Bengal's revenue base.

Qualification: This staged account should not be read as a smoothly planned strategy; each stage responded to immediate crises more than to any single long-term design formed in 1757.

Verdict: The Company's transformation was driven, at each stage, by the widening gap between its expanding footprint and the security of its revenue base -- a gap the first two stages failed to close.

Why this earns marks: Full marks require distinct, correctly sequenced stages with named drivers, plus the cross-stage continuity argument, and an explicit caution against over-reading the sequence as deliberately planned from the outset.

Mains 11 - 20 marks | 300 words

Question: "The settlement of 1765 created a divided sovereignty in Bengal that no single institution could be held fully accountable for." Discuss this statement with reference to the Diwani-Nizamat split and the Dual Government (1765-72).

Directive alignment: "Discuss... with reference to" requires engaging the accountability claim specifically, using both named institutions as evidence.

Introduction: The 1765 settlement's defining feature was not an absence of power, but a deliberate separation of power from responsibility across two institutions simultaneously.

The Diwani-Nizamat split itself: The Treaty of Allahabad gave the Company the Diwani -- land revenue collection and civil justice -- while the Nizamat, covering criminal justice and nominal military command, remained formally with the Nawab; a real legal division, in which the Diwani was substantively far more consequential.

Operationalising the split -- the Dual Government: The Company administered its Diwani through Naib Diwans, Indian intermediaries who exercised real administrative power without ultimate accountability to Bengal's population, while the Nawab's own office, formally responsible under the Nizamat, lacked the revenue and administrative machinery to act on that responsibility.

Testing the "no single institution accountable" claim: This is well supported -- the Company disclaimed direct administrative responsibility while governing "behind the curtain," the Naib Diwans answered to a Company that bore no formal welfare duty itself, and the Nawab's office had responsibility on paper but no operative power; Clive's own 1772 testimony describing pervasive "confusion and mismanagement" is direct evidence contemporaries recognised this gap.

Consequence: This diffusion of accountability is a structural explanation for administrative failures culminating in the 1770 famine, and is precisely why Hastings's 1772 reform sought to close the gap by making the Company itself directly answerable as Diwan.

Qualification: The claim should not imply total institutional collapse; revenue was in fact collected and courts did function -- the failure is one of accountability, not total non-function.

Verdict: The statement holds: 1765's divided sovereignty let both the Company and the Nawab's office avoid full accountability, a vulnerability only addressed by Hastings's 1772 structural change.

Why this earns marks: A strong answer connects the legal split to the operational accountability gap, cites Clive's own testimony as evidence, and distinguishes diffused accountability from total governmental collapse.

Mains 12 - 20 marks | 300 words

Question: "The conquest of Bengal is best understood not as a single battle or treaty but as a decade-long process of corporate-state formation, co-produced by Company initiative and Indian institutional choices." Critically evaluate this characterisation with reference to Plassey, Buxar and the Dual Government.

Directive alignment: "Critically evaluate... with reference to" requires testing the "process not event" and "co-produced" claims against named evidence from all three episodes.

Introduction: Read across Plassey, Buxar and the Dual Government together, this characterisation withstands scrutiny on both its central claims, provided each is precisely evidenced.

Testing "a decade-long process, not a single event": Plassey (1757) changed Bengal's ruler but not its legal-constitutional position; real institutional change required Buxar's 1764 victory and the 1765 Diwani grant; even then, the Dual Government was itself an unstable, transitional arrangement, only resolved by Hastings's 1772 decision -- a full fifteen years after Plassey.

Testing "co-produced by Company initiative and Indian institutional choices": At Plassey, the conspiracy network supplied the mechanism of victory as much as Clive's own planning; at Buxar, the coalition's segmented command was itself an Indian-side institutional choice that shaped the outcome as much as Munro's unified leadership; under the Dual Government, Indian Naib Diwans were the actual administrative machinery through which the Diwani operated at all.

Weighing the "corporate-state formation" framing: This is best read through the corporate-military-fiscal state lens (Marshall, Bayly), while the nationalist lens (Dutt, cited in Chandra) supplies the necessary moral-economic counterweight regarding the extraction this process enabled.

Qualification: "Co-produced" should not imply equal power or shared benefit; each Indian actor operated within a constrained, unequal set of options, and the process's ultimate institutional beneficiary was unambiguously the Company.

Verdict: The characterisation is substantially sound: 1757-72 is best read as an extended process of corporate-state formation in which Indian institutional actors were indispensable, though the process's power remained fundamentally asymmetric throughout.

Why this earns marks: A top-band answer tests both halves of the characterisation against named evidence from all three episodes, invokes the correct historiographical lens by name, and adds the asymmetry qualification.

FINAL CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES - TOPIC 04

Rapid recall: the four things to fix before an exam

RAPID RECALL

Dates to fix

Plassey 23 June 1757. Buxar 22 Oct 1764. Treaty of Allahabad 12 Aug 1765. Dual Government ends, 1772.

Names to fix

Mir Jafar (1757), Mir Qasim (1760), Shuja-ud-Daula, Shah Alam II, Muhammad Reza Khan, Warren Hastings (1772).

Numbers to hold loosely

29 English dead at Plassey vs 'nearly 500' on the Nawab's side -- textbook figures, not exact modern counts.

Boundaries to respect

No invented Black Hole toll; no monocausal famine claim; drain and land-revenue depth stay with Topic 07.

Original deterministic study visual - Modern History Topic 04 - Run this checklist the night before revision, not the morning of the exam.

Visual 26: Sixteen-cell rapid-recall grid: one key fact per subtopic

Visual 26: Sixteen-cell rapid-recall grid: one key fact per subtopic. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

1. Bengal's political economy before 1756

- Murshid Quli Khan (Diwan from 1700, Nawab from 1717) introduced ijaradari (revenue farming) and shifted the provincial capital to Murshidabad.
- Alivardi Khan won the 1740 Battle of Giria over Sarfaraz Khan to become Nawab; note this is a different battle from Mir Qasim's 1763 defeat at a place also called Giria.
- The 1717 Farrukhsiyar farman gave the Company duty-free trade in its own registered goods via dastak passes -- a Company-only, bounded privilege.
- Dastak abuse (servants using passes for personal, unregistered trade) was resisted by Murshid Quli Khan, Alivardi Khan and Siraj-ud-Daulah alike; keep this abuse pattern analytically separate from the farman itself.
- Fort William's unauthorised fortification (1755) was the proximate trigger for the 1756 crisis, not dastak abuse directly.

2. Calcutta crisis and the Black Hole, 1756-57

- Sequence: fortification dispute (1755) -> Kasimbazar factory seized (June 1756) -> Fort William falls (20 June 1756) -> alleged Black Hole (same night) -> Clive/Watson recapture (2 January 1757) -> Treaty of Alinagar (February 1757) -> Chandernagore falls (March 1757).
- The Black Hole rests on John Zephaniah Holwell's single, interested account; no independent corroboration of casualty numbers exists.
- The episode's contested memory is documented directly: the Holwell monument was removed from central Calcutta in 1940 amid nationalist campaigning.
- Treat the Black Hole as a source-criticism case study, not a settled casualty count; never state a specific death toll as fact.
- Chandernagore's capture (a French, not Company, factory) removed Siraj's potential French counterweight just as the Plassey conspiracy was maturing.

3. Plassey, 23 June 1757

- Conspiracy network: Mir Jafar (Mir Bakshi), Jagat Seth (banking house, credit-protection motive), Rai Durlabh (Diwan), Amichand/Omichand (broker, deceived by the forged "red treaty").
- Real fighting was confined to Mir Madan's and Mohan Lal's small loyal wing; Mir Jafar's and Rai Durlabh's wings never engaged.
- Traditional casualty figures (about 29 Company dead, several hundred on Siraj's side) are textbook figures only -- always qualify them as such, never as audited counts.
- Read Plassey as a political coup, not a conventional military triumph; it changed Bengal's ruler, not its legal-constitutional position.
- Immediate settlement: Mir Jafar installed as Nawab; the Company received the 24-Parganas zamindari plus roughly Rs 1.77 crore in compensation and gifts (a scholarly estimate); Clive received a personal jagir. The Diwani did NOT come from this settlement.

4. Post-Plassey extraction and Mir Qasim, 1757-64

- Post-Plassey extraction circuit: Mir Jafar's payments -> Clive's personal fortune and jagir -> Company political leverage -> escalating fresh demands -> Mir Jafar's 1760 deposition once he could no longer pay.
- Mir Qasim (Nawab 1760-63): relocated capital to Munger, modernised his army, tightened fiscal administration; his 1763 abolition of internal transit duties aimed at equal taxation for Indian and European traders alike.
- Company servants' loss of their duty advantage produced escalating conflict: the October 1763 Patna Massacre and Mir Qasim's defeats at Katwa, Giria and Udhana.
- Mir Qasim fled to Shuja-ud-Daula's Awadh, where the coalition that met the Company at Buxar took shape.
- Distinguish Mir Jafar's period (1757-60, extraction/dependency) sharply from Mir Qasim's period (1760-63, reform/conflict) -- a frequent actor-confusion trap.

5. Buxar and the Treaty of Allahabad, 1764-65

- Buxar coalition: Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula (Nawab-Wazir of Awadh), Shah Alam II (proclaimed emperor in Bihar, 1759, a fugitive without a throne).
- 22 October 1764: Hector Munro's unified Company command defeated the coalition's larger but segmented force (three treasuries, three commanders, no shared war-chest).
- Two treaties, same day, 12 August 1765: (a) Shah Alam II granted the Diwani of Bengal-Bihar-Orissa for a 26-lakh annual tribute plus the ceded districts of Kora and Allahabad; (b) Shuja-ud-Daula's Awadh restored for a 50-lakh indemnity. Treat these as two distinct instruments, not one combined document.
- Diwani (Company, via Naib Diwans: revenue collection, civil justice) vs Nizamat (Nawab, nominal: criminal justice, titular military command) -- legally separate, practically both Company-influenced.
- Buxar and Allahabad, not Plassey, created the Company's durable legal revenue title; Plassey only changed the ruling personnel.

6. Dual Government and the 1770 famine, 1765-72

- Dual Government (1765-72): Company holds substantive Diwani through Naib Diwans (Muhammad Reza Khan, Bengal; Raja Shitab Rai, Bihar); Nawab retains nominal Nizamat.
- Accountability paradox: Company power without formal responsibility; Nawab's office responsibility without real power. Clive's own 1772 testimony: "corruption universally prevails, and confusion and mismanagement pervade every department."
- 1770 famine: compound causation only -- poor 1768 harvest + 1769-70 drought meeting revenue rigidity, commercial priorities, and Dual Government administrative confusion. Never assert a monocausal claim or a specific mortality figure as settled fact; any scale estimate must be explicitly flagged as a repeated secondary-source estimate.

- Warren Hastings ended the Dual Government in 1772 by having the Company itself "stand forth as Diwan," assuming direct administration -- an internal reform, not Crown annexation (which came only in 1858).

7. Company transformation, Indian agency and historiography

- Three-stage transformation: trading company with local privilege (pre-1757) -> political kingmaker (1757-64) -> direct revenue sovereign (1765-72).
- Indian agency spectrum: each named actor (Mir Jafar, Jagat Seth, Amichand, Mir Qasim, Siraj-ud-Daulah) made a constrained institutional choice; avoid a single "betrayal" or "victimhood" morality play.
- Historiography: nationalist (R.C. Dutt's "open plunder and loot," cited in Bipan Chandra) emphasises economic exploitation; collaboration thesis emphasises specific elite interest-alignment; corporate-military-fiscal state (P.J. Marshall, C.A. Bayly) emphasises institutional fusion of trade-tax-war; Bengal political-economy view (Sekhar Bandyopadhyay) emphasises continuity within Bengal's own structures.
- These lenses are complementary, operating at different analytical levels (moral-economic vs institutional-structural vs elite-interest vs regional-continuity), not rival "correct" answers.

8. Master date table

Date	Event
1717	Farrukhsiyar farman grants Company duty-free trade in its own goods
1740	Alivardi Khan defeats Sarfaraz Khan at Giria, becomes Nawab
1756 (June)	Kasimbazar seized; Fort William falls (20 June); alleged Black Hole
1757 (Jan-Mar)	Calcutta recaptured (2 Jan); Treaty of Alinagar (Feb); Chandernagore falls (Mar)
1757 (23 June)	Battle of Plassey; Mir Jafar installed as Nawab
1760	Mir Jafar deposed; Mir Qasim installed
1763	Mir Qasim abolishes internal duties; Patna Massacre; defeats at Katwa/Giria/Udhanala
1764 (22 Oct)	Battle of Buxar
1765 (12 Aug)	Two Treaties of Allahabad: Diwani grant + Awadh restoration
1765-72	Dual Government under Clive's design
1770	Bengal famine
1772	Warren Hastings ends Dual Government, Company "stands forth as Diwan"
1773	Regulating Act (bridge to Topic 06 -- not analysed here)

9. Comparative quick-reference

Dimension	Plassey (1757)	Buxar (1764)	Allahabad (1765)
Mechanism	Political conspiracy	Unified command vs segmented coalition	Negotiated legal grant
Changed	Bengal's ruler (personnel)	Military-political balance	Legal revenue title (Diwani)
Durability	Personalist, revocable	Established military dominance	Institutional, durable

10. Topic-boundary map

Adjacent theme	Owning topic
European-company beginnings, pre-1757 rivalry	Topic 03
Mysore, Marathas, Sikhs, broader territorial expansion	Topic 05
Regulating Act 1773 and constitutional structure	Topic 06
Full economic impact, drain of wealth, land revenue systems	Topic 07

11. Rapid-fire traps to avoid

- Do not merge the 1717 farman with dastak abuse -- one is a bounded Company grant, the other is unauthorised servant misuse.
- Do not state the Diwani was granted in 1757 -- it was 1765, eight years later, via Buxar and Allahabad.
- Do not describe Plassey as an evenly matched pitched battle -- it was substantially a pre-arranged political coup.
- Do not cite Plassey casualty figures as audited certainties -- they are textbook figures only.
- Do not confuse Mir Jafar's 1757-60 extraction period with Mir Qasim's 1760-63 reform period.
- Do not treat the two 1765 Allahabad treaties as a single document.
- Do not describe the Dual Government as equal joint rule by two Nawabs.
- Do not assert a monocausal famine explanation or an invented mortality figure.
- Do not claim any PYQ is directly routed to Topic 04 -- the verified count is zero; adjacent items must carry their true owning topic.

12. Bounded bridge forward

- Topic 04 ends its narrative at 1772-73. The Regulating Act's constitutional reforms belong to Topic 06.
- The fuller economic-impact and drain-of-wealth analysis, and detailed land revenue systems (Permanent Settlement onward), belong to Topic 07.
- The broader territorial expansion this Bengal base financed (Mysore, Marathas, Sikhs) belongs to Topic 05.
- This topic's own bounded contribution is the Bengal conquest sequence itself: political economy, crisis, conspiracy, battle, extraction, reform, coalition, decisive battle, legal grant, and the accountability failure of the Dual Government through to its 1772 termination.